# You're My Happily Ever After

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/84024051.

| | |
|---|---|
| Rating: | Teen And Up Audiences |
| Archive Warning: | No Archive Warnings Apply |
| Category: | Multi |
| Fandom: | She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018) |
| Relationships: | Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Melog (She-Ra), Kyle/Lonnie/Rogelio (She-Ra), Entrapta & Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra) |
| Characters: | Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra) |
| Additional Tags: | Magicat Catra (She-Ra), Catra is Whipped (She-Ra), Beta Read, Princess Adora (She-Ra), Magicat Adora (She-Ra), Lesbian Disaster Adora (She-Ra), Adora Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Catra Needs a Hug (She-Ra), idiots to lovers, magical transformations, Alternate Universe - Fairy Tale, Adora is what happens when you lock a person in a tower for 10 years and expect them to come out okay, Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Catra Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Angst with a Happy Ending, they're in LOVE your honour, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Wingman Melog, multiple POVs |
| Language: | English |
| Series: | Part 1 of To Be With You In Paradise |
| Stats: | Published: 2026-04-30 Completed: 2026-07-02 Words: 33,401 Chapters: 6/6 |

# You're My Happily Ever After

by Princess_Cyra

Summary

She was in danger from the moment she cried for the first time. She was hunted from the moment she could take her first steps. She was an abomination the moment they noticed her ears and tail. She was something to be feared the moment someone saw her claws. She was a danger to society the moment they realised what she truly was.

Catra was not welcomed to anything, or anywhere for that matter, and that was how she liked it. Watching people cower in fear at the sight of her, despite her short stature was a deadly drug, one she consumed regularly. It gave her the opportunity to do as she pleased, live in a remote cabin far away from everyone with the knowledge that she could remain undisturbed. What more could anyone want beyond that?

[OR]

When her land and her cabin are taken over by exiled hybrids, Catra sets off on a journey with her companion Melog to save a princess and get back the home that was taken away from her.

# Chapter 1: One

*Once upon a time, in a kingdom far far away, there was a lovely princess. Her hair shone in the sun, making it look like spun gold. Her eyes glowed in the moonlight like sapphires, and her demeanor made her beloved by all who met her. She was the dream of every man, all of them fought like cats and dogs for her hand, but she had her sights on just one person, her true love.*

*An enchantment had been placed upon her at birth, it plagued her during the nights and made her untouchable during the day. Fearing for her future, her aunt and uncle sought the help of a sorceress to reverse her curse. The sorceress couldn't achieve the feat, so she changed the Princess's curse to add a failsafe.*

*"She can only be cured by true love's kiss. Only someone worthy of this pure love can reverse her fate and return her to normalcy." The sorceress stated to the aunt and uncle.*

*Now there was only one question on the pair's mind, how do they find someone worthy to save their beloved niece?*

*To them, there was only one answer: A challenge.*

*They locked their niece in a fortified tower, guarded by a feral beast to keep her safe. Only the most worthy, brave, and kind-hearted warrior could make it past the beast and save their beloved niece from the curse that plagued her life.*

*Who would that warrior be?*

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

She was in danger from the moment she cried for the first time. She was hunted from the moment she could take her first steps. She was an abomination the moment they noticed her ears and tail. She was something to be feared the moment someone saw her claws. She was a danger to society the moment they realised what she truly was.

Catra was not welcomed to anything, or anywhere for that matter, and that was how she liked it. Watching people cower in fear at the sight of her, despite her short stature was a deadly drug, one she consumed regularly. It gave her the opportunity to do as she pleased, live in a remote cabin far away from everyone with the knowledge that she could remain undisturbed. What more could anyone want beyond that?

The cabin she stayed in was all she had left of her family. They weren't well off, this was the only settlement they had beyond their home in Duloc. It was a small, one floor cabin out in the middle of nowhere, surrounded by flowery bushes and trees. There was a bed, a kitchen, a bathroom and that was about it. It was cozy, and all she really wanted and needed in life. Food was never a concern, she lived in a forest and could hunt smaller animals to satiate herself. There was a lake 1 km away where she could rinse herself off, and if she ever got

bored, there was a small cupboard in her bedside drawer filled with her mother's fairy tale books, the only remnant of her left in the world.

She lived near the village of Elberon, a small settlement of merchants and craftsmen. Ever since Catra moved into the small cabin, she'd become a sort of horror story for the local children.

*"They say that the creature of the woods tears out the hearts of unruly children and feasts upon them in front of our very eyes."*

*"She skins her victims and uses it as a disguise for when she hunts at night to lure us out of our homes."*

*"She can mimic the voices of those she's consumed before too!"*

*"She's bloodthirsty and doesn't care what she does to get her next meal. Do not **ever** cross the beast's path."*

If the rumours were funny, the pictures they drew of her were a comedy performance. She came upon a few of them while she was out on a nightly spree to steal some basic groceries. Catra was a depicted as a completely black figure, and she was able to make out the silhouette of her messy hair, pointy ears and her sneaky tail. The only pop of color on the page was her bi-colored eyes and the blood that ran down her mouth.

Most people would be offended, but Catra only chuckled. If she had to give her opinion on the matter, she would say that she was a busy woman who didn't have the time on her schedule to harvest the skin and hearts of unruly children, not when she could be doing more cultured things like painting or enjoying a good book.

No one ever cared to ask her opinion, though. In their mind, she was already a monster from the depths of their nightmares. Who was she to burst their bubble?

Her morning routine was simple. She awoke hours after sunrise, cleaned her teeth and her body before having a breakfast of pancakes or eggs that she would steal during her nightly runs. After an hour or relaxation which would either be spent painting or reading her mother's books, she would go out into the forest to hunt her lunch, returning most of the time with a deer or something similarly sized.

She would nap for a couple hours after lunch, and when she arose, she would go out into the forest to find her dinner. After dinner she would sit outside her home and stargaze, or simply enjoy the nature around her.

Many would call this routine dull, and Catra would agree. It was a miracle she hadn't perished from boredom, but after the harsh life she'd led, paralysed by fear and panic, worried that one wrong turn could leave her on the wrong side of a hunter's gun, she was grateful for this life.

*You could be worse off*, Catra would tell herself. *You could be dead in some ditch, but you are alive, you are peaceful and more importantly, you are **safe**. Enjoy the life you have.*

Catra had long since learnt to accept her gifts and not ask for more. Besides, she didn't *need* anything more. A roof over her head, food on her plate, clothes on her body? That was a miracle on its own, more than she ever deserved, and she was ready to fight tooth and nail to *maintain* it.

It was a night like any other, Catra was enjoying a meal of a deer she'd caught and roasted while adding a spice rub. Living alone all her life had made her experienced with cooking. It was quite reasonable to feel extremely irritated when she was interrupted by loud noises down the road.

"The beast lives here, in that grove."

"How preposterous! Such a beautiful scenery, marred by the presence of that *demon*."

"Do not worry, brothers, we shall rid ourselves of the hellspawn tonight."

Catra rolled her eyes, putting her dinner aside and making her way out the door and into the darkness of the trees.

It didn't take her long to find the group that had so rudely interrupted her meal. They were a handful of men, no older than twenty, all carrying lit torches in their hands, muttering to each other about the danger they were about to walk into.

"The creature can morph and shift into any form it desires, but it will always carry those markers that show it isn't human like we are." The leader mumbled to his group. "When we have our sights on it, we must take it down and burn it to a crisp, are we clear?"

The rest of the men nodded passively, and Catra couldn't help but grin at their stupidity. Humans relied on the supernatural to explain *everything*, it simply didn't seem to register that sometimes, the reason someone is different from themselves has to do with genetics. Nonetheless, Catra wasn't going to disregard their delusions, what's life without some fun and whimsy?

She snuck up behind the men, running her tail across one of their backs before disappearing into the trees once more. The man gasped, turning around to see if he could spot the being that touched him, growing pale when all he could see was the road that they had taken to come here.

"It's here!" He gasped to the others. "The beast has entered our vicinity!"

His words threw the whole group into chaos, just as she wanted. They began to shine their torches around, trying to see if they could catch a glimpse of her. They never would, years of running and dodging had made her agile. They would never catch her.

They continued to circle around themselves, like dogs chasing their own tails. Catra followed their movements closely, a grin flitting across her face.

*What fools. All the bravado was just for show, they are nothing more than feeble ducks compared to me.*

“Show yourself, demon!” The leader declared, raising his torch above his head as though it would attract her out of her hiding spot like a moth.

*Well since you’re asking so nicely…*

Catra left her cover beneath the trees, moving soundlessly so that she would end up behind them. “Is it me you’re looking for?” She cooed, batting her eyelashes at the men. The group turned around to gaze upon her, their eyes wider than the saucers she stored in her cabin.

“It is the beast!” The leader declared, pointing at her. “She has taken the form of a young maiden to bait us, do not fall for her tricks, brothers!”

*My goodness, I am not a siren!*

“Are you quite sure? I assure you, I do not bite…” Catra responded, a sweet smile morphing her features into an expression of innocence.

“Step away from us, you temptress!” Another man exclaimed, shoving the torch in her direction.

Her smile fell, and with an eye roll, she reached out and blew a gust of wind at the torch, extinguishing it with ease. The men began to squeal like pigs now, and the noise was like nails on a chalkboard for her sensitive hearing.

“Brothers, she is stronger than I realised!” The man who’s torch was now useless whimpered.

“Well you were the one who decided to be brave, knowing the stories that surround my existence~” Catra said with a shrug, taking a step closer to the group. “My my, what strong men. I can *feel* your hearts **beating** deep in your chest. Goodness, it has been a while since I fed.”

The men were trembling in their boots, the youngest now crying into the leader’s shoulder. Catra opened her mouth and snarled at them, baring her fangs to them. The group’s scream echoed through the forest, and they ran out of the forest without tossing a glance at her. Catra chuckled, shaking her head at how easy it was to scare them when she noticed a piece of paper on the ground. She picked it up and turned it around in her hand. It was a flyer from the kingdom of Duloc.

**Wanted: Hybrids, Magical Creatures and all their Protectors**

**You will be paid a sum of 300 gold coins per every hybrid who is turned in to the soldiers of Duloc.**

*Ugh, of course.*

With an eye roll, Catra returned to her cabin, crumpling the flyer and tossing it behind her. As the Monster of Elberon, she had her perks, and one of them was that people were terrified to be near her. She was going to be okay.

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

They'd been dreading this day for so long. They'd begged Willa to keep them, promising that she'd come out of poverty soon. In hindsight, this day was inevitable, Willa had a weak heart, she would've caved in eventually. The fate of a Hybrid Protector was then that of the Hybrid.

Willa dragged Melog's as the line began to grow smaller. They'd shifted into a normal panther so that, at the very least, the guards would assume that Willa was playing a trick on them. She'd grown angry when she saw what Melog had done, and despite all of her beatings, requests and threatening demands, they didn't budge.

Eventually, she'd grown tired of negotiating with Melog, and had dragged them out to meet the soldiers. They followed along wordlessly, despite everything, they still cared deeply for Willa, somehow, losing their freedom seemed *worth it* if the young girl could get some money out of it, she'd suffered for too long.

"Take them away!" The guard yelled. Melog looked up to see two humans and a large lizard being sent away into a massive cage. They were tied up in chains, and shortest one, a blonde boy, was patting his lizard companion on the arm with a somber look. In another cage, a large scorpion hybrid woman was chained up with much shorter woman, her purple hair gesticulating wildly, somehow still energetic despite the awful situation they were trapped in.

There were too many hybrids to keep track of, the numbers continued to grow. There were foxes, wolves, bunnies, and all the hybrids were being joined by talking animals, smaller fairies, sirens whose mouths had been *sewn shut*, giants…

It was a heinous scene, how could people be so cruel?

Their leash tugged so hard against their throat, Melog nearly choked as Willa dragged them to the front. When they looked up, they finally realised why.

They were at the front of the line.

"Name, Creature you have come to deliver." The bored guard at the table said to her.

"Willa Quinn, and I have come to deliver a shapeshifting cat." She whispered, tugging Melog forward.

The guard glanced down at what seemed like a normal panther, before rolling his eyes. "Can you prove it?" He asked.

"Yes! Yes I can!" Willa responded immediately, before tugging on Melog's leash. "Speak! Change! Come on I *know* you can." She begged in a desperate voice.

Melog growled in response, trying to pull themselves out of the leash, using their magic to change their size in a covert size. If they could just escape from this, they would be free to roam the woods and the guards would never suspect them.

*Come on, just a little more.*

"Do not do this to me!" Willa whined, tears streaming down her face. "Please, please, believe me, they can shapeshift!"

“Just seems like a normal panther to me.” The guard said with a shrug.

“No *no*! They can, I swear they can! Melog, Melog please, I need this, I need the money, just *show them*!”

“**NO!**”

Their yell echoed across the ground. In the span of a second, the leash shattered and Melog’s panther form changed back into their normal, purplish and airy form. They could feel the guards eyes on them, gawking at their alien being.

Without any warning, Melog sprinted out of the clearing and into the trees surrounding the camp.

“Grab it! Do not let it escape!” The leader declared, and pretty soon, Melog could hear the sound of metal crashing into each other as the guards started to follow them.

Melog couldn’t tell where they were going, they were just running, the only thought in their mind was **survival**. They needed to run, they needed to get away, or else they would *never* be free.

“It’s going that way! Surround the thing, men!” A female soldier ordered. Melog immediately switched directions, running onto the path instead. They could distract the guards, make them go in another direction and use that as a cover to escape. Yes, that was a good plan.

They ran down the path, dodging boulders and other wild animals before running back into the forests once more. They’d lost most of the guards by this point, there were only four following them now.

*You’re almost there!*

Melog crashed right into someone, falling like to the ground. Their vision was blurry now, both from the running and from slamming their head into a person. The girl in question growled at the disturbance, but Melog couldn’t get a good look at her.

“I found the creature!” A soldier yelled in triumph. Melog whined, and with what little energy they had, the took to hiding behind the the girl.

The remaining four soldiers immediately arrived, surrounding Melog and the crouching girls. They immediately froze at the sight of her, and the feline could hear one of the soldiers, possibly the leader, gasping in disgust.

“What a horrific sight!” He exclaimed, reaching into his pockets to pull out a scroll. He unfurled it while shaking in terror, clearing his throat to announce the message to the girl.

“By the decree of Lord Prime, you are ordered to turn yourself over to the army of Duloc so that you will be sent a-away- i-into-” The girl rose from her kneeling position, the hood of the cloak she was wearing fell of her head to reveal messy brown hair and *cat ears*. The girl

rolled her wrists, and when she opened her hands to show off her claws, Melog realised they were **extremely** bloody.

“I’m sorry, what were you saying?” She asked in a sweet voice.

“I-I must take you into isolation buildings, so you will surrender yourself, or else we will make you!” The leader finished, still trembling at the sight of the girl, despite the fact he was considerably larger than her.

“*We*? Honey, there’s no **we**.” The girl said smugly, pointing behind the leader. He looked behind himself only to realise that his men had run at the first sign of danger.

“You have ten seconds to run before I kill you.” The girl threteaned, but the leader didn’t have to be told twice. He ran right out of the trees, a strangled cry escaping him.

Melog giggled to themself while the girl leaned down and grabbed the dead carcass of a wild boar, using her cloak to wipe her face. Only then did Melog get a good look at her.

She was a magicat, one eye blue like the sky while the other was yellow like sunflowers, Melog’s favorite flowers. She walked past Melog without throwing them a glance, the feline immediately got up and began to follow her.

“What you did back there was *amazing*!” They gushed, running a little faster to catch up with the girl. “You were **incredible**!”

“Are you talking to **me**?” The brunette asked in an annoyed tone, eyes drifting down to meet Melog’s.

“Yes! I am!” Melog responded eagerly. “Those guards were actin’ all high and mighty, but just one look from you and they were tripping over their words and feet! Gosh, it’s so great to be free…”

“That’s amazing, now why don’t you go celebrate that with your friends?” The girl suggested, walking faster like she really needed to be somewhere. Willa’s desperate face came to mind, and Melog’s ears drooped. They couldn’t return to Willa, not after they’d betrayed her like this. Willa would just try to sell them off again.

“I do not… have anyone to go to.” Melog admitted, their eyes lighting up when they noticed the magicat. “Can I stick with you?” They asked, sprinting again so that they could match her pace.

“Goodness **no**!” The magicat said immediately. “I do not need roommates.”

“You don’t realise what you need until you have it.” Melog argued, moving to stand in front of the girl and stomp their paw stubbornly. The girl hissed in displeasure, clearly angered by their stubborn behaviour.

“Do you not **realise** what I am?” She asked, gesturing to herself.

“You’re a super cool and friendly stranger!” Melog responded confidently, their tail wagging eagerly behind them.

The girl was taken aback by their response, and when she started walking again, Melog following behind like her shadow, she didn’t protest.

“What’s your name?” They asked curiously.

“Oh. It’s- It’s Catra.” She responded, tightening her grip on the wild boar.

“That’s a nice name! I’m Melog, it’s nice to meet you.”

“Nice to meet you too…”

The two of them walked through the forests in silence after that. Melog admired the forests, the flowers, the animals scampering across the branches. They were never allowed outside when they lived with Willa, this was all quite new for them.

Eventually, the trees began to grow scarce until the path they were walking on opened up into a massive clearing. It was filled with grass, rose bushes, butterflies and more insects. In the center was a sparsely decorated cabin, Catra's scent hitting Melog with full force.

“Is *this* where you live?” Melog asked excitedly, looking up at Catra with stars in their eyes.

“Yup, this is my home…” Catra responded but Melog didn't wait for it. They ran out into the clearing, diving into the grass and rubbing their body into it. A happy laugh escaped them as they dove into the rose bushes to chase after butterflies and bees. It was so much open space! Melog could run around everywhere, they could finally feel free, they wouldn't be restricted to just four walls and the same old rooms.

Catra didn't say anything as she watched Melog sprint across the lawn, growling playfully at insects and squirrels as they bounded up trees to escape their jaws. She watched in silence as they ran around and rubbed their body on everything to their heart’s content.

Eventually, she made her way to the front door, trying to open it silently, but nothing could make it past Melog’s ears. They immediately bounded towards the door, slipping into between Catra's legs to enter her home and make themself comfortable on one of her dining room chairs.

“Your home is so nice! So cosy!” Melog complimented as they wiggled on the chair to find the perfect way to curl up and nap.

“I- I didn't allow you in here. You need to *leave*!” Catra exclaimed, laying the corpse of the boar on her table.

*What? No no no!*

“Wait please! I can't go, I can't leave, *they're looking for me*!” Melog begged, ears drooping as they imagined their rotting, bloodless corpse on the ground, surrounded by a bunch of guards, all cackling at the pathetic sight they were witnessing.

“That's not my problem.” Catra responded, moving over to bathroom to wash the blood off her nails and her face.

“Catra please!” Melog jumped off the chair, running over to her feet to rub their face against her leg. “You know what it's like to be considered a freak around here, they'll *kill* me! Please, please don't send me back there.”

For a few terrifying minutes, Catra simply stared at Melog, clearly thinking over the feline’s words. *Please please, don’t send me away*, Melog thought to themself, *I won’t live, you’re my only hope*.

“**Fine**…” Catra whispered reluctantly. “You can stay here. I’ll feed you, give you water, whatever. But you’ll stay and sleep outside.”

“That’s okay! That’s more than okay!” Melog began to jump and down, running circles around Catra while rubbing their body along her legs.

“Yeah yeah, go outside now, you little brat…” She chided, moving over to open the door for them. Melog immediately sprinted outside, diving into the bushes surrounding the cabin.

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

The night was extremely cold, even Catra, with all her fur, couldn’t handle it. She’d taken to wearing a woolen bathrobe so that she could stay warm.

Melog was outside, curled up in front of the front door. Over the last two days, they’d taken to curling up there when night fell. They’d said that it was comfortable spot to nap in, but Catra knew the true reason. They were guarding her home, just in case those guards, or anyone else, came to finish the job. She’d never asked them to, they did it anyway.

She should call them inside, it was cruel to leave the little creature, no matter how annoying they may be, outside in such weather. They had followed Catra home, looking for safety, and had taken to protecting Catra as though it wasn’t the other way around. They deserved this much at least in return.

She wrapped her bathrobe around herself, lighting up a candle before making her way to the front door when she heard it, whispering outside her home. Her tail began to swish, her fingers itched as her claws grew sharper. People were outside her home, and they were trying to make sure she didn’t know it.

A quiet snarl escaped her. Melog was out there all alone, were these people trying to kidnap them? No, she wouldn’t allow it. Melog had come to her, hoping to be protected from the dangers of the world. She wouldn’t break that trust, even in death.

Without warning, she threw open the door, wielding her candle like a weapon. The hoards of hybrids gathered outside her home jumped in shock, holding onto each other as they watched her with fear in their eyes.

Catra couldn't count the sheer number of hybrids, they went into the hundreds. There were foxes, wolves, lizards, magicats like herself, but also sirens, giants, shapeshifting creatures like Melog. Speaking of Melog, they were curled up with a few of their kind, chatting animatedly about the wind until a young girl in the corner cried out, "*It's the Monster of Elberon!*"

"Hey! She's no monster! She saved me from those guards!" Melog argued, huffing and moving over to take their side next to Catra.

"What is going on, Melog!? Who are all these people?" Catra demanded, glaring down all the hybrids who were currently *on her land without her permission*.

"Lord Prime's soldiers abandoned them here, said they were above driving them to a facility and said they should rot here in the woods." They explained, glancing over at all the hybrids with a look of pity.

"Seriously? Here of all places?" Elberon wasn't dangerous by any means, but Catra had no idea how all these hybrids would survive out here together. There were no proper homes for them to stay in, and some of them were clearly suffering. She could a young siren girl being helped out by a fox and an otter hybrid to remove the stitches that were keeping her mouth shut, sobbing as they did so.

"The soldiers dumped us over here, they didn't even want to travel two minutes with us." A young woman standing beside a lizard hybrid responded. She was a human, so Catra deduced that she and her blonde partner were probably Hybrid Protectors.

*Great, now I have a bunch of hybrids and magical creatures living outside my cabin.*

Honestly, Catra could kick them of her land, they were tresspassing after all. She and Melog could then live in peace without ever encountering rogue hybrids ever again. Yet, as she watched them comfort each other, remove their chains and the stitches, a question popped in her mind, in a voice that wasn't her own.

*Would the guilt of leaving them to die ever leave you, Aaron?!*

Catra groaned quietly, before looking to the front of the group. "You two! What are your names?!" She demanded, pointing at the girl with braids and her blonde companion.

"Lonnie and Kyle. This is Rogelio." The girl added, pointing to her lizard companion.

"What about you two?" Catra then pointed to a scorpion woman and her purple haired human.

"Scorpia and Entrapta." The scorpion woman responded.

"Great." They seemed okay physically. Most of the hybrids were either wounded or sick, but they seemed like they could feasibly look after the group until Catra returned. She'd feel good leaving them in charge.

“The five of you are going to look after the group, procure food and water and correspond with me while I travel through Duloc to discuss with Lord Prime on how to transport you all safely to a new location.” Catra announced, tossing off her bathrobe and hanging it on her coat rack beside the entrance.

“What?” Lonnie asked, taken aback by Catra's words. “Why- Why are you doing this for us?”

“All of you are on my land, until you leave I will not know peace. I'm doing myself a favour.” Catra responded harshly, because she didn't feel ready to reveal the true reason to people she barely knew.

Lonnie didn't seem to phased by her answer, she simply shrugged while Catra called one of the healthy talking birds to her, instructing it to come to her for letter updates everyday, before finally turning to face Melog.

“You're coming with me.” She whispered, gesturing to the path ahead. Melog’s eyes lit up with excitement, bounding over to the road with a high pitched squeak.

“Yes! Yes let's go!” They cheered, bursting into a happy song about two friends travelling together to save the world. Catra sighed, not finding it in herself to tell the feline off for singing so loudly, following them down the path while hugging herself tightly.

*I hope you are proud of me, mother.*

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

# Chapter 2: Two

Chapter Notes

> thank you to my amazing beta reader LesbianSimp who also wrote the mirror's intro speeches for Mermista, Perfuma and Adora!

His patience was at its end. It'd been two days, and the hybrids hadn't been delivered to the correctional facility designated to them. He had sent out a word to the leader of the guards stationed at Elberon, and after recieving no response, he sent his men to bring the leader to his knees and back to Duloc. Those who disobeyed him needed to feel the darkness, after all.

His brothers brought the dishonored soldier in by his arms, tossing him onto his knees in front of Prime's throne. He was beaten up badly, open bruises were all over his arms and his face. Carelessly, Prime placed his foot under the soldier's chin to lift his face, opting to make eye contact with the man.

"Welcome back to Duloc, brother." Prime greeted, a *pan am* smile spreading across his face at the fear on the soldier's face. "I trust you had a safe trip?"

"Y-Yes Lord Prime! A most wondrous journey." The soldier responded, nodding vigorously as he spoke.

"I see, well isn't that just amazing! A most wondrous journey, then pray tell, where are the hybrids you picked up at Elberon?" The soldier's face fell at the question, eyes growing wide as hepondered over what lie would be believable enough. The soldier must not be well-trained if he believes that Prime would fall for his lies.

"The hybrids escaped their cages Lord Prime!" The soldier exclaimed. "They escaped and attacked us, before releasing their friends and running into the woods. There were hundreds of them, we weren't able to find them once they all ran."

"Ah. Why, that is just unfortunate. Do you perhaps know the hybrid that started this little rebellion?" Prime was really just humoring the soldier at this point. He already knew why the hybrids weren't delivered to the facility.

"W-Well- Are you aware of the Muffin Man?"

*Oh, what an interesting turn of events.*

"The Muffin Man? The one who lives on Drurry Lane?" Prime asked curiously, smirking down at the soldier.

"Well- She's married to the Muffin Man…"

“The Muffin Man?”

“*The Muffin Man*!”

For a moment, the entire room was silent as they watched to see how Prime would react to such nonsense. Instead of anger, or disgust, the young Lord burst out laughing, running a hand through his hair before looking back down at the soldier.

“*She’s married to the Muffin Man*. Goodness, I have not heard something so nonsensical in a long time. You **amuse** me, brother.” Prime complimented, the rest of his court chuckling along with him. “It is quite a shame that I’m going to send you down to the dungeons, you would've made a fine court jester.”

The soldier began to plead with him, begging Prime to give him a second chance, promising that he would bring the hybrids back, but Prime did not listen.

“Brothers! Take him away! Show him what happens to those who do not appreciate the light of Lord Prime.”

Two soldiers grabbed their dishonored comrade, dragging him out of the court room into the dark tunnel beside the throne. Slowly, the screams of the dishonored soldier retreated, until they could no longer be heard.

It was truly a shame, Prime would've enjoyed his presence.

“My Lord!” His attention went to the front. His messenger ran in, panting heavily while a soldier carried a large object under a piece of cloth. “My Lord, we have found it, we have found the object you have been seeking out.”

*Ah, finally! My search for the hybrids can continue another time.*

“Wonderful news, brothers! Come, we shall take it to my chamber.” Prime said, rising from his throne and guiding his two servants down to his bedchamber.

They placed the relic on his dresser, before removing the cover to reveal the magic mirror that Prime had been searching for for years. The mirror swirled before turning into a vaguely female face, her eyes blinking as she awoke from the slumber the cloth had drawn her into.

“Evening. Mirror mirror on the wall, is this not the most perfect kingdom you have ever laid your eyes upon?” Prime asked, sauntering closer to the mirror on his dresser.

“Uhm- Technically this isn't a kingdom.” The mirror responded, glancing around the room to observe all the people who were present.

“I beg your finest pardon?”

“This is not a kingdom, because *you* are not a king.” The mirror explained.

“Hm, brother.” Prime called out to his guard, giving him a nod before the guard grabbed a small hand mirror, and much to the magic mirror's dismay, proceeded to smash his hand into

it.

“You were saying?” Prime prompted to the mirror with a handsome grin.

“W-What I meant is that y-you aren't a king *yet*, but you will be after you marry a princess!” The mirror continued, flashing Prime a nervous smile.

“Go on.” He prompted, pulling up a chair to sit down in front of the mirror.

“Well you sit back and relax, my lord, you will be introduced to today's eligible bachelorettes!” The mirror said in a game show host type voice. Prime’s messenger and guard began to clap along with the mirror, but Prime didn't give the mirror that satisfaction.

“Bachelorette number one is sarcastic lady who’s a big fan of sushi and quality time spend in hot tubs or pools, with her commanding presence she's stolen the hearts of many sailors. Give it up for *Mermista*!”

“Bachelorette number two has a personality full of flower power, but don't mistake her love for plants for weakness, because even the most beautiful roses have thorns. Round of applause for *Perfuma*!”

The other two men in the room were giggling and whispering to each other like school boys who were snooping on the their female classmates in the locker room. Prime could barely hold himself back from rolling his eyes.

“Last but most **certainly** not least we have bachelorette number three. With her heart of gold she's easy to love, but unfortunately not as easy to find. Locked away in a tower protected by a vicious beast, a man has yet to save this beauty. Make some noise for *Adora*!” The mirror displayed the image of a young girl with blonde hair that was pushed into a braid long enough to reach her waist. She was seated on the window of a tower, her bright blue eyes almost glowing with her longing from freedom, somehow shinier than the silver dress she was dressed in.

This was it. She was the girl Prime wanted, and he wouldn't rest until she was **his**.

“So will it be bachelorette number one, bachelorette number two or bachelorette number three?” The mirror asked, glancing over all three men in the room.

“Number three.” He said without any hesitation. She was the one he wanted.

“Great! Though I should tell you about the little thing-”

“Brothers!” Prime rose from his chair, turning to face the two men in his room. “We will be hosting a challenge tomorrow to pick my champion!”

“Your champion?” The messenger asked in a confused tone. “For what?”

“Lord Prime- she has this little problem that happens at night!” The mirror exclaimed, but Prime paid her no mind.

“My champion who will ride to Princess Adora's tower to save her for me, obviously! Gather our best soldiers and warriors, the winner of tournament will have the honor of fighting and bringing back my beloved bride!”

Prime turned to face the messenger with stern eyes. “Go on now! Send the message to my brothers!”

“Of course Lord Prime!” The messenger bowed and left the room along with the guard.

“Soon I shall be married, and then this kingdom will be the most perfect kingdom you've ever seen. Am I correct?” Prime turned to face the mirror who nodded mutely in response.

“Good.”

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

“So how far is Duloc from here?”

Catra sighed, rubbing her forehead while walking through some tall grass that was currently tickling her legs. This was the tenth time Melog had asked that question in the last two hours.

“We’re almost there.” She said in a very irritated tone. “We should be seeing the palace of Duloc anytime now.”

“That's great! Can't wait to finally reach it!” Melog exclaimed, running in front of Catra, stopping for a minute to sniff some pretty flowers. The brunette shook her head and continued to push her way through the grass.

“How come you know the way to Duloc?” Melog asked curiously, running a little to catch up with her pace.

“I used to live there, back when it wasn't ruled by someone so maniacal.” Catra responded, choosing to give only surface level information. Melog didn't need to know the intricacies of her story.

“Oh! Oh that makes sense.” The feline nodded like Catra had dolled out some sage advice, before looking back at the path they were walking on.

It didn't take long for Catra to sense the familiar scent of her home, her fur standing on end, her tail poofing up. *Goodness, I never thought I'd be back here…*

Melog seemed to sense it too, he began to run faster till they reached the end of the cliff, gasping when their eyes finally landed on the palace.

*Duloc.*

Somehow it was larger than what Catra remembered, the palace was now tall enough to touch the clouds covering the sky.

“**That's** Duloc?” Melog asked, giving Catra a wide eyed look while pointing at the massive palace with their paw. The thing took up ninety percent of the land of this kingdom. How does anyone have any space to set up houses or markets?

*God, is he compensating for something?*

“That's so cool! Come on, let's get a closer look.” The feline ran forward down the slope of the cliff, Catra following close behind, albeit much slower. The closer she got to Duloc, the more her flight or fight response was being triggered, unforgiving memories flashing in front of her eyes.

*“Mama? Mama!?”*

*“Run Catra! We'll buy you some time!”*

*“Papa no! Please don't go!”*

*“Aaron they're following her!”*

*“Don't let them get our girl!”*

*“**We love you Catra… Now go, live the life we never could.”***

“Wow. This is so much bigger in person…” Melog whispered in awe now that they were at the foot of the kingdom gate.

“Yeah. It is.” Catra responded, walking forward and pushing the gate open, bracing herself for screams and noises of disgust, or at the very least prayers for god to take away the spawn of Satan that had walked onto their holy ground.

The screams never came. In fact, she didn’t hear a single sound because there was no one around. The streets were completely empty, and so silent that she could’ve heard a pin drop. It looked like a ghost town.

“Where is everyone?” Melog asked, leaning down to sniff the ground, probably to find the residents through their scents. Catra followed them with focus, until they led her straight to big Information Box with a lever beside labelled *Pull Me!* Melog, who has the impulse control of a newborn puppy, immediately went over to the lever, grabbing it with their mouth and pulling it as instructed.

It began to release a *tick tock* kind of sound. Melog squeaked and ran to hide behind Catra who hissed at the offending box. The sound reminded her of a goddamn **bomb**, she’d experienced enough of those to last her entire life.

The doors to the Information Box burst open, a bunch of wooden puppets joining along as they began to sing.

“*Welcome to Duloc, such a perfect town! Here we have some rules, let us lay them down!*”

The snarl that escaped Catra was nothing short of dangerous. She did not need to relive her childhood cult drama any more than she did everyday, because that was what this song was, propaganda. Melog seemed to appreciate the tune though, they were nodding their head along with the song.

A camera flash accompanied the final lyric of this song, providing the duo a printed photo with the message *'Welcome!'*. Catra grabbed it and crumped it up, much to Melog's dismay.

"I liked that photo…" They mumbled, trailing behind her sadly.

The two continued to walk around town, glancing in shops and in the open windows of homes, once again finding no sign of human life.

"Did everyone in this town just disappear?" Melog asked after twenty minutes of aimless walking.

"If I'm being honest, I wouldn't be surprised if they had." Catra admitted, Duloc's kings were… *eccentric*, to put it nicely.

"Welcome fellow Brothers of Duloc!" A booming voice announced from straight ahead. Catra and Melog turned to find the gates of the arena open to the public. Inside Catra could hear the indistinct voices of people chatting animatedly with one-another while Prime eagerly announced a challenge between his knights.

"Looks like we found where everyone ran off to." Catra mumbled to Melog, walking right over to the entrance of the arena, her companion following along while humming the tune of the cursed introduction box song.

"..the person who wins this challenge will have the honor, no no, the *privilege* to journey to Princess Adora's tower and rescue her for me so that I can make her my bride and the Queen of Duloc!" Prime was announcing to the crowd and the group of ten knights currently standing in a line on the arena. "Now, if for any reason, the winner is unsuccessful in rescuing Princess Adora, the first runner up will take his place, and so on. Some of you will most definitely perish, but that is a sacrifice that I am willing to make."

*Oh good, Lord Prime is just as* ***eccentric*** *as the kings who came before him*, Catra thought to herself with an eye roll.

The audience were squealing and clapping at Prime's announcement, and all Catra could do was watch in utter confusion. How are any of them actually enjoying this? All of it went out the window when she noticed a man carrying a massive board with the word **applaud** written on it.

*Somehow he manages to be worse, oh good heavens…*

"Let the tournament begin!"

*Goodness I don't have time for this.*

Catra shoved past the knights, walking straight towards the podium where Prime's throne was placed. Everyone gasped as the brunette made her presence known, arms crossed over her chest while she glared at Prime.

"Ugh! It's hideous!" Prime declared, his eyes wide and face morphing into an expression of disgust.

"How *dare* you! Melog is **extremely** adorable, thank you very much." Catra responded in a sassy voice, while the feline in question glanced between the two with a confused expression.

"Indeed… Brothers! I have a new challenge. Whoever kills the hybrid will be dubbed as **Duloc's champion**!"

*Oh dear…*

The knights turned to face Catra, pulling out their swords and approaching the brunette slowly. Her back slammed into a wooden table, when she turned she saw it was beside two massive beer barrels.

"Come on, can't we sit down and discuss with a glass of beer?" Catra asked her attackers as she grabbed a filled glass of beer from the table. Her attackers didn't give her the satisfaction of a response. "No? Well alright then." She chugged the liquid while Melog began to climb up the second barrel. Catra then proceeded to slam her glass down into the tap of the closest barrel, beer began to pour out of it onto the sand of the arena with such force that it shattered the front of the barrel.

"Come on then!" Catra yelled. "*Have at me*!"

The beer had made the sand extremely soggy, so it was easy for Catra to just slide across the ground, dodging the knights who lunged at her with ease. She caught one of the female ones with kick aimed at her stomach, sending her straight to the wall before grabbing her spear and slamming it right onto another night's head to leave them disoriented enough for Catra to grab their helmet and give them a good punch.

"Move out of the way, I'm comin' through!" Melog declared excitedly, since now they were on top of the untouched barrel. They began to roll it down the arena, catching a number of guards and crushing their bones under the weight of the wooden barrel. This left just four more knights for Catra to take down.

She ran into the wrestling ring, the four remaining knights hot on her heels. They surrounded her in the ring, the only weapon she had was the spear she'd stolen from the other female knight.

"Oh dear! You have me surrounded! However will I escape from this tragic mess?" She gasped, throwing her hair back and batting her eyelashes at the four knights. "Oh I know, like this!" She landed back against the elastic ropes surrounding the wrestling ring and launched herself at the knight closest to her, landing right on top of him and opening his visor to ram the spear into his face. She then grabbed his corpse and tossed it at another knight, rendering the second unconscious.

The last two were shaking where they stood, but we're unwilling to dishonor themselves by quitting. The last female knight ran at Catra and tried to grab her and beat her into the ground, but the brunette was much more flexible compared to her, easily able to twist herself out of the woman's grasp and kick her into the ropes. The last one was just as easy, Catra had their hands behind their back in minutes when she heard someone calling her name.

"Catra! Catra, *tag me*, ***tag me***!" The brunette looked up, Melog had their front paws hanging over the ropes as they stood on their hind legs, eagerly waiting for Catra to drag the knight over to them. Catra smiled and obliged, bringing the knight over to Melog so that they could slam their head into the knight's and knock them out, ending the tournament with a flourish.

Catra was gasping for air, she hadn't been in such an unbalanced fight since she was a young teenager, it has quite literally knocked the wind out of her. Now that she had a moment to rest though, she could hear screams in the background. She panicked for a moment, worried that the denizens of Duloc were protesting against her, yet the screams didn't seem like ones of anger, no they sounded more pleasant, excited even.

The denizens of Duloc were *cheering for* ***her***. They were cheering for her victory.

It was an exhilarating moment, she stepped out of the wrestling ring and with a wide grin, she waved at the citizens who were now rising out of the seat to celebrate her win. This was the last thing she'd expected, but she wasn't complaining. It felt so good to be celebrated like this, especially in the kingdom from which she'd forcibly chased out.

Catra heard the sound of metal on metal. She looked to the high towers of the palace where the guards lining them were aiming crossbows at her and Melog. She turned to face Lord Prime, who was sitting with one leg over the over, eyeing her thoughtfully.

Prime rose from his seat, smiling with pride at the audience. "Brothers and Sisters, I present to you the Champion of Duloc!"

"**What**!?" Catra could barely hear herself speak as the audience burst out into loud screams, clearly happy that she'd been declared their Champion.

Prime rose from his seat and walked forward so that he could stand face to face with Catra on the arena. "Tell me little sister, what do you want your prize to be?"

"I want my cabin and my land back." Catra demanded, arms crossed over her chest.

"Your land?"

"Yes. **My** land. The one where *your* men dumped all those hybrids because they were too *disgusted* to travel with them. The one where they're currently suffering with no food, no shelter and no safety."

Prime hummed thoughtfully, observing Catra as though he were picking out all her flaws, all the things that made her tick. Catra didn't flinch under his stare, if anything she *glared* ***harder*** at him.

“I want you to remove the hybrids from my land deliver them to a safe, *secure*, location where they can live peacefully and won't be disturbed by hunters, poachers or soldiers.” Catra demanded, not worried about the fact that she was doing this in front of the entire kingdom. She had an opportunity and she was going to make full use of it.

“It shall be granted, little sister, under one condition.”

“What condition?”

“You will travel to the Whispering Woods, and you shall save Princess Adora from the tower she is kept in so that I can make her my queen.”

There was pure silence in the arena. Everyone watched with bated breath to see how Catra would respond. The brunette stared quietly at Prime, the words echoing in her mind.

It was a *suicide* mission. Adora was guarded by a beast with the sole purpose to weed out those who are unworthy of saving Adora. There was a very low chance that Catra would make it out alive. It would leave the hybrids vulnerable to Prime's will, should she accept the deal?

This was the one chance she had to save those hybrids. She should do it, if only for those hybrids suffering in pain in her backyard.

“You've got yourself a deal.”

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

*Dearest Lonnie,*

*I hope you and the rest of the hybrids and creatures are doing okay. I’m afraid my trip will go on longer than I initially planned. When I arrived at Duloc, Lord Prime was holding a tournament to choose a Champion who would save Princess Adora from her tower. Upon my arrival, the challenge was changed, and whoever ended my life would be declared the winner. Since I am alive, you can safely deduce that it did not come to pass, I took down my opponents with relative ease, and since none of his knights won,* ***I*** *was declared Duloc’s Champion. Lord Prime offered me a deal. If I were to retrieve Princess Adora, he would bring you all to new homes where you will remain undisturbed. It is very likely that I will not survive this ordeal. If that happens, please take everyone and find a safe location to hide, because I am sure Prime will do whatever it is he wants with you. I will try to ensure my safe return, unfortunately I cannot guarantee it.*

*Yours faithfully,*

*Catra.*

Catra rolled up the letter and handed it to the bird, who was named Rosalind. She took the letter into her mouth and flew out into the sky to return to Catra's cabin and deliver the letter. Melog had fallen asleep, curled up next to fire she had started to cook some dinner on.

A lot of things had happened after she accepted Lord Prime's deal. He'd made sure that the brunette had everything she needed to ensure a safe trip, namely food, water, change of clothes, a cart to travel in and a map to guide her on the correct route. The journey to Adora's tower took one week, so she'd be on the road for two weeks before her fellow hybrids would be brought to safety, that was assuming she survived Adora's rescue.

Melog was quite optimistic about this journey, they chatted eagerly the whole ride out of Duloc, where Catra was given quite a grand farewell. The entire kingdom was there to cheer her on as guards walked on either side of her. She felt like a sort of war hero, which was quite ironic considering the last time she left Duloc, those same guards who guided her were the ones chasing her out.

It was currently nighttime, Catra was curled up on the grass right beside her cart, mind on the impending doom she was driving herself to. She was crazy to think she could waltz into that tower and defeat that beast like she was the protagonist of some romantic novel. What worried her more was the fact that the *beast* chose if the person was worthy of Adora.

Her survival hinged on whether or not a bloodthirsty beast thought she was worthy to save her beloved Princess. *Fantastic*. It would be a miracle if Catra made it out alive, let alone in one piece. Saving Adora was out of the equation entirely.

However, it didn't matter if she thought she could do it, those hybrids were relying on her to help them. She had no choice, Catra needed to do it, at least for them.

Tomorrow, Catra and Melog would enter the forests of the Whispering Woods and start the journey to Princess Adora's Tower. If there were no unexpected weather complications, and if their journey went without any attacks, they should reach the Tower in one week's time.

One week from now, Catra would face the beast, and from then her fate was a mystery.

*Mother, father, if you are listening to me, please bless my trip, and please ensure that I make it out alive with the Princess.*

After that short prayer, Catra fell into a restless sleep, filled with nightmares of Lord Prime, the beast of the castle, and two glowing blue eyes of a young princess.

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

*One Week Later*

It was a beautiful day. She rose from her bed with a bright smile on her face, grabbing a beautiful red dress with a long cape and a decorative gold belt around the waist, before making her way to her bathing chambers.

Adora had a good feeling about the day, like everything she'd ever wanted would be fulfilled. She went through her morning routine with a happy demeanor, humming a gentle tune to all the animals that came to her window to be fed while she made her own breakfast. Even Ophelia noticed her sudden mood change, considering she'd been sullen the entire week.

*“Someone's happy.”* She commented as Adora made her way down the spiral staircase to her chamber. *“You even dressed up today.”*

Adora spun around, letting the material of the skirt flow so that she could show off gorgeous dress. “I just had a good feeling about today!” She explained, moving over to sit beside the massive beast.

Ophelia was pure white, with the appearance of a ram, especially with her massive horns. From either side of her horns were veils made of leaves and flowers, the same garland extending from her behind, ending with a fluffy tail colored in a mixture of purple, pink, blue and green.

She seemed threatening, and she was, but she was also kind, and gentle, and motherly to Adora. During the ten years she spent here, Opie looked after Adora and made sure all her needs were met. She didn't think she'd get a… *marital night* talk from a beast meant to kill unworthy knights, but it happened, and she was extremely grateful.

*“That's great honey. If you think it's going to be a wonderful day, then it will be.”* Opie responded, smiling fondly at Adora, before returning to grooming her paws.

Adora stayed down there for a while, chatting about everything and nothing while Opie groomed herself and purred, nuzzling into Adora's hair every now and then as quick affection.

It was mid afternoon, Adora was half way through explaining the book she was reading when Opie’s head shot up and she glanced outside the window.

“Are you okay?” Adora asked her.

*“Yes dearest. I believe a young knight has come to rescue you.”*

Adora's heart rate increased ten fold when she heard that.

“Really? Can you see him from here?! What does he look like?!” Adora asked excitedly, already jumping up to see who it was, but the window didn't face the front of the castle.

*“I cannot see them, but I can hear them. They are at the front entrance, and I believe it is a woman, dearest. Not a man.”*

A… woman? A female knight? This has never happened before.

“A female knight has never stepped into the grounds of the palace. Can she even be my true love?” Adora asked, rubbing her hands nervously.

*“It's always good to give her a chance. I will go upstairs and attack her as though she were any other knight. We shall see how she fares in combat.”* Ophelia rose from sitting position, making her way up to the main floor of the palace, Adora hot on her heels.

“I'll wait in my room.” Adora whispered, still feeling a sense of excitement at the prospect of being freed from this tower and this curse. So what if her true love isn't what she expected?

She would love them all the same. Man, woman, it didn’t matter as long as they rescued her.

It all hinged on whether Opie found this young woman worthy, and deep down, even though Adora didn't want to admit it, she hoped this woman was the one for her.

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

# Chapter 3: Three

The palace was nothing like what Catra had expected. She'd thought it would be a dilapidated mess, rooms broken, holes everywhere, bodies of all the knights who's came before laying around, flesh torn apart as the beast slowly worked through eating them. Instead, the palace was located in a flowery grove, a curtain of flowers masking the entrance to it. The inside was clean and well maintained, not a single speck of dust on the walls or the decorations lining the entrance pathway.

"Are you scared?" Melog whispered as they walked down the hall, watching as Catra grabbed a sword from a nearby suit of armor before wrapping a cloth around the lower half of her face to hide her identity.

"No…" Catra responded, trying her best not to sound annoyed.

"Oh good, I'm not afraid either, because I am big, scary shapeshifting cat, and only cowards would be afraid of something when they're more than capable of escaping, and I am not a coward in any way. I am brave, capable cat, not a coward-" A loud squeal escaped Melog when they ended up stepping on a spider, immediately launching themselves into the air and making Catra grab them.

"*Okay*. I need you to **shut up**. Is that clear?" Catra asked in an overly sweet tone, to which Melog nodded vigorously. "Good, now go over there to those steps and see if you can find the Princess's room. Make sure to check all the rooms, this palace is huge."

"Yes ma'am!" Melog jumped out of her arms and immediately ran down the hall and went up the steps to the first floor, leaving Catra alone and with her own thoughts.

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

Melog had checked all the rooms in the first floor, all of them were empty. *Honestly why would a palace have so many rooms?* Melog thought to themselves as they reached the steps to climb to the second floor when they noticed one room they didn't check. The door was much larger compared to all the other rooms they'd just checked, so they decided to give it a shot.

The door released a loud creak as it opened, making Melog flinch as they walked in. It seemed like they'd walked into a ballroom of sorts, it was completely dark, the windows were closed up with curtains and all the furniture had been removed, making every step echo.

*Okay, clearly this isn't the princess's room.* Melog thought to themself. *Time to check the second floor.*

Just as they were about to leave, they heard ruffling on the ceiling, the noise of something trying to move in a way that wouldn't alert other creatures to their presence. It suddenly dropped right behind Melog, a soft hum accompanying it's footsteps as it crept closer. Melog

turned around, eyes going up and up and up until they met the crystal blues eyes of their pursuer.

The beast growled at Melog, a soft warning that had their tail tucking itself in between their feet.

*Oh no.*

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

Catra couldn't find anything useful for fighting off the beast in the ground floor rooms other than more suits of armor, and she'd already grabbed a sword from one of them. It was honestly disappointing. She returned to the main foyer, deciding to go upstairs and find where Melog was.

“AAAH!! CATRA?! CATRA WHERE ARE YOU!”

*Speak of the devil and they arrive… why are they screaming?*

Melog ran out of a massive ballroom on the first floor, running down the steps as a massive goat-shaped white beast ran out of the room after them.

*Oh shit that's why.*

When the beast's eyes landed on her, it released a loud snarl, immediately launching itself down the steps to grab her. Catra immediately dodged, rolling across the floor while Melog tried to escape from the beast's jaws.

Once Catra was out of its sight, the beast rounded on Melog, trying to grab their tail in it's mouth, but the feline was faster and smaller than the beast, able to squeeze into spaces that the beast couldn't reach.

Catra went around the other side, climbing onto the the beast's tail to hopefully make it onto her head. If she could just blind the beast, it would be easier to save the princess.

It didn’t work as Catra expected. The beast turned around as soon as Catra reached her tail, the beast began to shake it around, bringing Catra along for that ride.

“Catra!” The brunette glanced around to find Melog watching her with worry.

“Melog I’ll be okay! Just *run*!” Catra yelled back, gripping onto the beast's tail with her claws.

Without warning, the beast launched its tail up into the air, sending Catra into the highest floor of the palace. She ended up crashing through the door into the only lit room she'd found in the whole palace. Catra growled, shaking her head before pushing herself up to check where the beast thrown her.

The last thing she expected to see was a young, blonde woman with bright blue eyes dressed in a gladiator-style dress, a gold belt around the waist. She was sitting on the bed, a rose on

her lap, and she was staring at the brunette with wide eyes, clearly not having expected to see her rescuer.

*Okay come on Catra, you made it this far, can't chicken out now.*

Catra got off of the floor, dusting off her outfit and moving over to the princess to kneel in front of her on one knee. “Your majesty…” She whispered in a low voice. “It is an honor to be in your presence.”

Adora blushed, tucking some hair behind her ear and looking over to the side. Catra smiled, even though it wasn't visible with the cloth covering half her face. “It is a pleasure to meet you…” Adora whispered in a flustered voice, fiddling with the rose in her hand.

Catra smiled softly. The Princess was prepared for this in every way except mentally. “Is that for me?” The brunette asked gently.

“Y-Yes… uhm, I was growing this in the gardens outside so that I could give it to the person who rescued me…” Adora responded, offering the rose to Catra. The brunette took the rose before rising off her knee and extending a hand to the blonde.

“Why don't we get you out of here princess? I think you've been in this tower longer than you've wanted to be. We can have this conversation outside.” Catra suggested, placing the rose in her pant pocket.

“W-Wait…” Adora stuttered, somehow her blush growing darker than it already was. “Aren't you- *going to kiss me*?” The last part ended up much quieter than the rest, but Catra picked it up quite easily with her magicat hearing.

Thank god she was wearing a cloth on the lower half of her face, because she was sure even her fur couldn't cover up her flustered expression, the only sign that she was affected by the question was how her pupils grew larger, but Adora didn't know her long enough to pick up on it.

“Woah princess, you haven't even asked my name~” Catra teased, mostly to cover up just how much that request made her heart pound.

“What is your name?” Adora asked, her eyes wide with curiosity.

Catra needed to take Adora and leave, *now*. She had no clue how long the beast would leave Melog alive, and she sure as heck wasn't going to abandon them, but maybe she could spare a few minutes to indulge Adora? The Princess had spent ten years all alone, dreaming of the moment someone would save her.

“I'm Catra, your majesty.” The brunette pulled off cloth so that she could speak to Adora face to face. The blonde's eyes landed on her long ears, before dropping down to her tail. She expected Adora to be repulsed by it, but she wasn't. Instead, she beamed excitedly.

“You're a magicat?”

“Yes princess.” Catra responded calmly, moving over to grab the sword from where she dropped it when the beast tossed her into the room.

“You're so pretty...” Adora cooed, pausing and covering her mouth when she realised she'd said it out loud. Catra chuckled warmly, tail swaying at the compliment.

“Why thank you~” The brunette said, attaching the sword to her belt before moving over to pull Adora off the bed. “Now come on, I still need to get you out of here.”

Adora squeezed Catra’s hand, still too shy to properly meet her eyes, but the brunette had expected it. The two of them then ran out of the room together, Catra guiding her down the steps while keeping her eyes and ears alert to search for Melog.

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

The beast had tossed Catra off into the ether, and now they were alone with it. The split moment where it was distracted, Melog sprinted off down the path to the other wing of the palace. They got into the bridge that led them there, and for a moment they felt joy. *I’m going to escape!* Melog thought to themself.

Suddenly, a large paw crashed into the bridge in front of them, smashing it into a million pieces. Melog squeaked, turning the other way only for that part to also be crushed.

They were stuck on this tiny piece of the bridge while the beast loomed over them, ready to kill them off like they were nothing.

The beast’s flowery veil leaned all around the feline, and in a split second moment, they rambled: “Oh wow what a gorgeous veil!”

The beast paused, eyes wide as they stared at Melog. The feline was just as confused as to why they said it, but it seemed to distract the beast, so they kept talking.

“Why yes! It is quite a lovely veil! You must maintain it well because it is blowing me away!”

The beast released a high-pitched, feminine giggle, seeming to calm down at the compliments.

“Oh! Oh you're a lady!” Melog exclaimed. The beast gave him an odd look, almost like she was conveying the words *‘was that not obvious?’*. “W-Why of course you're a lady! You are just reeking of feminine beauty!”

The beast purred eagerly, batting her eyelashes flirtatiously at Melog, before leaning closer and circling the feline with **intent**.

*Oh god what did I just unleash?*, Melog thought to themself.

Suddenly, both the beast and Melog began to glow a bright purple light, lighting up the entire room like they were disco balls. When the light faded, the beast leaned down towards Melog.

*“Now you're mine.”* She whispered, grabbing Melog’s tail with her mouth and carrying them away from the bridge.

*Oh no.*

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

When Catra reached the main foyer, the beast and Melog were nowhere to be found.

*Oh goodness did it eat them?! Oh my god Melog.*

“Are you okay? You look worried…” Adora whispered, looking around them room. She also seemed confused that the beast was nowhere to be found.

“I had a cat who came along with me. I have no idea where they are, and the beast guarding you is also not here, I am reasonably worried as to where my cat is.” Catra explained.

“Opie has a room down in the basement. You could check there. She doesn't eat anyone other than the knights who come for me.” Adora explained casually, as though that wasn't what Catra was *worried about*.

“Okay. Wait up here. I'll be back.”

“Well I can't go anywhere else…” Adora pointed out with a shrug.

“…you have a point.” Catra relented, before making her way down to the basement steps, praying that Adora was right and *Opie* didn't like eating animal sidekicks.

She opened the door slowly, thanking the gods above that being a magicat ensured that her footsteps were inaudible. She expected a lot of things, she expected Opie to be torturing Melog, or at least in the process of killing Melog. What she hadn't expected was Opie to be curled up around Melog, purring and grooming them.

“L-Look I really like you- But I don't think I’m not ready for a relationship, especially a physical relationship of this… magnitude…” Melog explained, seeming extremely awkward around Opie.

The beast in question growled in an offended tone at Melog.

“No I'm not calling you fat! I’m calling you huge, there's a difference.” Melog responded, sounding just as offended. Opie released a more angry growl at that.

*Oh my god Melog, you weren't going to die before but you are going to now!*

“I'm not calling you fat, Ophelia. When I said huge, I was talking about your height. I’m like an ant compared to you! How would that even work?”

Opie whined at that, nudging her head against Melog, almost like she was begging Melog to stay.

*Oh stars above, what is going on?!*

“I like you but I just don't think this is even feasible. I do think you're gorgeous!” Melog insisted, moving closer and purring to try and comfort Opie. “How about this? I finish this thing with Catra and I come back to you and we talk this out?”

Opie released a questioning whine, giving Melog a hopeful look.

“I won't stand you up, I promise! I never break a promise.” Melog assured her, smiling sweetly at the shapeshifting being.

Seemingly satisfied with that answer, Opie let the feline go. Melog immediately sprinted up the steps, squealing in surprise when they saw Catra.

“Oh hi!” They greeted, like they didn't just make a shapeshifting being fall in love with them in under five minutes.

“You and I will be having a word. Come on, I got Adora.” She pulled Melog into her arms and sprinted up the steps. Adora was still in the foyer waiting for Catra. The brunette grabbed her by the arm and the three left through the main entrance.

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

Adora hadn't felt so light in her life. She hadn't left the palace for ten years. If she did, it was only for a few minutes to experience the fresh air, and it was never during nighttime. Her aunt had forbidden it.

Catra and her sweet cat were currently packing up a few things onto the cart they'd come on, choosing to give Adora some privacy as she adjusted to being free. The blonde didn't understand how she'd got to be so lucky, Catra was so sweet and thoughtful, not to mention pretty. Adora couldn't wait to spend her life with her.

Just as soon as Catra kissed her and removed her curse.

Maybe she'd been staring a little too much, because Catra smiled curiously at her before telling Melog to look after the horses for a few minutes. She walked over to Adora and nudged her shoulder.

“How's freedom treating you princess?” Catra asked gently.

“It feels nice… being trapped in that tower sucked. I lost hope that anyone would ever save me.” Adora admitted, looking around to watch a few birds singing in a nest.

*Ok so how do I bring up my curse to her in a way which isn't pushy?* Adora thought to herself while rubbing her arm nervously. It's an awkward thing to ask a stranger to kiss you after knowing them for less than thirty minutes because they're destined to break your curse. It didn't help that this particular stranger was making Adora feel things she'd never felt before.

Apparently she didn't need to bring it up, because Catra seemed to sense that something was troubling her. “What's on your mind, princess?” She asked.

“D’you know the story about why they left me in that tower?”

“Oh uhm, no… Should I?”

*I'm sorry, what?*

“Uh you should. I've been cursed, and only my true love can save me from that tower and kiss me to lift my curse!” Adora responded, her voice growing more high pitched.

Catra blushed fifty shades of red in the span of ten seconds, her tail poofing up behind her. “U-Uhm princess- I hate to break it to you, but I am not your true love. I was uh- I was sent as Duloc’s Champion, Lord Prime of Duloc is the one who wants you- n-not me.”

*Oh. My. God.*

“You must be joking with me. If you are not, then please get on that cart and inform your *Lord Prime* that I do not want to marry him unless he saves me himself!” Adora declares loudly, because there is no world that the blonde would accept this. She wants *Catra*, not some coward who’ll send others to do his work.

“Your majesty, I know this is coming as a shock, but I assure you Lord Prime is an admirable match!” Catra grabbed her hands, giving her a very unconvincing smile.

“I do not need you to sell me his wonderful qualities, no matter what they may be!” She pushed Catra's hands off of herself, feeling quite rejected. For a few moments, she'd genuinely believed she and Catra had *something*, now she’s realising that the thing between them is Lord Prime.

“Princess please, I understand how you're feeling but you're making my life *much harder* than it needs to be.” Catra growled, rubbing her forehead with an irritated sigh. “Please just get on the cart… I promise that Lord Prime will treat you well.”

*But I want you to treat me well… You saved me, not him. Opie chose **you**.*

But maybe she didn't. Maybe Opie sensed that Catra was sent by someone else, and she chose him, not her. Adora didn't know how Opie worked, she didn't understand how Opie found someone *worthy*. Maybe she should give this Lord Prime a chance.

“Come on, let's get on the cart.” Catra took her gently and led her to the cart, helping her onto it before taking a seat next to her.

Adora was in an extremely bitter mood for the rest of the travel, and really could you blame her? For a few amazing moments, she'd believe that she was engaged to the most gorgeous woman she'd ever met, only to realise she'd saved Adora on someone else's orders. Catra didn’t say anything for most of the ride, sensing that the blonde needed some space to process this news.

They were honestly fit to ride all through the night, but as soon as the sun began to dip lower into the sky, Adora could feel her nails begin to itch beneath her skin and her head begin to hurt above her ears. They needed to stop and rest for the night.

“Catra… can we stop?” Adora asked quietly.

“Why, what's wrong?” The brunette turned to face her with wide eyes, immediately looking her over to see if she was hurt or sick. Adora clenched her fists, feeling her sharp nails dig into her palm.

“N-Nothing! I just want to rest for the night is all…” Adora lies, trying to give Catra her most convincing smile.

“Yeah I agree…” Melog chirped in from behind. “Today's been *exhausting*. Besides, I can see Rosalind circling us in the sky, you should reply to Lonnie’s letter and let her know that we’re returning to Duloc.”

“Right… Okay let's see if we can find a spot to rest.” Catra eventually gave in, and turned the cart to find a spot to slow down for the evening.

It took them a few minutes to find a beautiful clearing filled wish flower bushes and butterflies, and more importantly, a cave where Adora could hide out for the night, away from Catra and Melog. She'd immediately asked if they could stay there as soon as she saw it, and the gods had listened for once, because Catra didn't ask any further questions.

Catra lit a fire and began to cook a quick dinner with the supplies that her supposed fianceé, Lord Prime, had provided. Adora ate her dinner quietly, trying not to give away the excruciating pain she was in. Her head was throbbing, her lower back felt like it was ready to crack in half, and her nails were itching to be freed. As soon as she finished eating, she placed her plate aside and told Catra that she was going to go to sleep, and asked for help on closing the cave entrance. Once again, Catra asked no questions and helped her out, leaving Adora in the darkness where she belonged.

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

*Dearest Lonnie,*

*I am happy to inform you that the rescue of Princess Adora has gone smoothly. The Princess is now in my protection and I will now spend the next week ensuring that she's delivered to the safety of Duloc. Melog and I are okay, we didn't sustain any injuries from battling with the beast protecting the Princess, which is a surprise even to me. I shall continue to inform everyone of our progress over the next week, I am confident that it will be a smooth travel, considering what we have survived already.*

*Yours sincerely,*

*Catra*

The brunette rolled up the paper and handed it to Rosalind. “Here you go.”

“Don't I deserve some payment from all the flying I've been doing?” Rosalind asked in a sassy tone, fluttering her wings and refusing to take the letter from Catra.

“Well I cooked bacon, do you want that?” Catra picked up a piece of leftover bacon from her plate. She’d lost her appetite due to the adrenaline coursing through her veins from the day’s excitement. Rosalind hummed and immediately ate the bacon without any complaints, before taking the letter and launching into the sky.

Silence fell over the clearing, a warm blanket that Catra relished. After everything she'd done today, she couldn't believe she had survived. It felt like a fever dream, because there was no way Catra, who'd run from everything dangerous all throughout her life, had faced a beast head on *and* saved a gorgeous princess at the same time like she was the protagonist of a fairy tale.

Though it didn't feel like she'd saved Adora, considering she was driving her straight into a new nightmare, marriage with *Lord Prime* of all people. She couldn't forget Adora's reaction when she realised Catra hadn't come of her own free will, and was instead sent as someone's champion. For a moment, Catra believed that Adora was angry because she'd genuinely been excited to be engaged to *Catra*, but she dismissed that thought as soon as it came. Why would anyone want her? She had nothing to offer. She lived in a cabin in the middle of nowhere, and the only things she actually owned were her paintings. Everything else either belonged to her parents, or she stole them from Elberon at the dead of night.

No one wanted *her*, she never gave them a reason to.

“Catra!” The brunette looked up, smiling to see Melog running over to her, the feline immediately pouncing on her with the eagerness of a kitten.

“Hey, where did you go after dinner?” She asked them fondly.

“I went to chase after squirrels! Didn't catch any of them but I'm getting close!” They declared before settling themselves right next to Catra.

“That's great buddy.” Catra immediately began to scratch their ears while Melog purred like a motor.

They sat quietly for a few minutes, the only silence filling the ground was Melog’s gentle purring as they pushed their head into Catra's hand, but the brunette’s mind was racing. She didn't want to admit it, but over the last week, she'd grown attached to the young cat, but now it was registering in her mind that after she dropped Adora off at Duloc, she may never see them again and she'd be alone once more. It was easier to be alone when you didn't know what the alternative was, but now that she knew, she could never go back. It was pathetic, but feelings were like that.

“What are you thinking about?” Melog asked curiously, their big eyes blinking up at her with such innocence.

“Just the fact that you got an angry monster to like you in the span of five minutes. I was just upstairs talking to Adora, what magic did you perform?” Catra teased, ruffling their head playfully.

“Compliments do a lot for the ladies~” Melog responded, grinning widely at Catra while stretching out on Catra's lap. “I think you could benefit from it, considering how offended Adora became when she spoke with you.”

“She was offended because she found out I was sent by Prime.” Catra responded defensively, pouting at the feline and pinching their side, which made them giggle and roll of Catra.

“Where is the princess anyway?” Melog asked, rolling onto their belly and looking around for Adora.

“She's asleep in there…” Catra gestured to the cave in the corner currently covered by a rock at the entrance.

“*oh.*” They turned over to the rock at the entrance, giving it a suspicious glance, before sprawling out on Catra's lap with a trill.

“Will you be joining Ophelia in the palace after everything’s over?” Catra asked, already fearing the answer she would receive.

“I've not decided yet, why?” Melog asked, glancing up at Catra before their eyes went wide as a light bulb went off in their mind. “Oh my *goodness*! You're going to miss me aren't you!” They asked excitedly, shooting up and placing their paws on Catra's shoulders to face her properly.

“*Pfft*! No I'm not. I didn't want a roommate in the first place.” Catra bluffed, looking away from the feline and rubbing her neck nervously.

“You're going to miss me! I made you like me!” Melog declared loudly, their tail wagging back and forth as they beamed at Catra.

“Shush! The Princess is *sleeping*!” Catra hissed, pulling Melog down so that they would rest on her lap.

“For the record, I wasn't going to just *abandon* you. We’re best friends! I would never leave you! I would've made Opie move in next to the cabin, I'm sure she's not enjoyed being locked up either.” They responded with a shrug, smiling up at Catra like it was the most obvious thing.

“I don't know how I feel about having two roommates, especially one who's as large as Ophelia.” She pointed out, but there was no bite behind the comment. If anything, she was honoured that Melog would consider her like this. Before them, no one had done this for her, no one other than her parents anyway.

“You'll get used to it.” Melog responded with a shrug, before curling up into her lap and settling into a sleeping position. Catra laid down as well, beginning to purr as the two got comfortable. For the first time in a while, Catra felt happy about her future, knowing that her old, boring routine would finally be broken up.

Neither of them noticed that the rock on the cave had been moved slightly, and they especially didn't notice the pair of bright blue eyes watching their interaction closely.

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

# Chapter 4: Four

The rock was pushed aside, she stepped out slowly so that Catra wouldn't be alerted to her presence. The last thing she needed was for the feline to see her when she was still like this. The sun would rise soon, just half an hour more and she would be normal again, she could last.

She walked into the forest and took in a deep breath. The air in the cave was damp and heavy in a way that made her feel suffocated. She needed the fresh air, *desperately*, she couldn't stand being caged like that even though she'd asked to stay in the cave.

*Guess this is what it'll be like until we reach Duloc,* she thought to herself, rubbing her arm as she continued to walk around the forest.

A quiet chirp drew her attention to the tree next to her. A lovely bird was sitting in the nest, singing to her as the morning began to come around. Her tail began to swish behind her, pupils blowing out at the sight of the bird. Unbeknownst to the bird, she began to track it's movements as it fluttered from branch to branch.

A soft growl escaped her as she launched herself at the bird at the right moment, stabbing her claws into it and watching the life leave it in a moment's notice. When she pulled her claws out, it fell uselessly to the ground, it's pink feathers staining darker.

*I'm a monster*, she thought as her claws retracted permanently and her fur changed back into doll smooth skin. She picked up the bird and the eggs in it's nest to take it back to camp for morning food. It was nothing new, she knew what she was like, that's why she was locked away.

*Maybe when I return to Duloc, my marriage to Prime will save me, maybe I'll be cured.*

It was a hopeless thought, but hope was all she had, it was the only thing that was driving her forward, or else the depression from the curse would've taken her years ago.

*Maybe in one week's time, I'll be okay.*

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

*"How long will we be stuck here?" Daphne asked, hugging her brother's arm tightly while looking around the cave with fear in her eyes.*

*"I don't know… A long time, I'm assuming…" Her older brother, Anthony, responded, squeezing her shoulders comfortingly.*

*There were ten of them in that cave, only ten who managed to survive the soldiers' anger. Catra was oldest, and therefore, the leader, so while everyone hugged each other and cried, she stood tall and watched the entrance of the cave, just in case those soldiers returned.*

*“Shouldn’t we be going out there and fighting them ourselves?! They took our moms and dads, I don’t want to stay here when they hurt us like this!” Zoe screamed, pulling away from her brothers and stomping her foot stubbornly.*

*“Don’t be a dummy. They’d take us down in five minutes.” Catra hissed, turning around to glare at Zoe, who huffed and crossed her arms over her chest.*

*“Catra’s right…” Ishana, the more silent one, whispered, pulling her friend Lilianna closer to herself. “We should stay in here, it’s safer, we’re in no position to escape.”*

*Zoe didn’t like it, but her brothers tugged her back down to a sitting position. Catra turned around to face the entrance, the moon shining in the distance. It seemed like such a normal sight, even though her life was anything but. When she came back to herself, she glanced down and realised she was older, no longer the scared six year old anymore.*

*When she turned back around, her friends were corpses, blood pooling out of their clothes, their faces smudged like they were drawings on blackboards that’d been partially erased.*

***I can’t remember your faces anymore**…*

*Daphne tilted her head, her mouth opening as an inhumane scream echoed throughout the forest. Catra covered her ears and eyes, and when she opened them, she was in the forest, the carcass of a deer in her arms. She looked around to try and figure out where she was when soldiers ran past her, swords drawn as they marched straight into the cave.*

*Her friends began to yell and scream, the sound of flesh being torn apart echoed like a sick song. Catra dropped the corpse and ran into the cave to try and stop the guards, but it was too late, and there were already nine gravestones on the ground, flowers growing out from the Earth, the only thing burial she could afford to give them.*

***After failing you all, the least I could do is remember what you looked like, but I can’t.***

*“You promised you’d keep us safe…” Daphne asked her, her voice floating in from every corner of the cave, echoing in Catra’s mind.*

*“WHY DIDN’T YOU KEEP US SAFE!?”*

Catra jolted up from the grass, a strangled cry escaping her as she clutched her chest and gasped for air, Daphne’s words still ringing in her ears. Her head was spinning and air was so hard to breathe in. *This is it*, she thought. *They've finally come to take me away too*.

“Catra!?” It was a distant voice, she couldn't focus on it no matter how hard she tried. “Catra!” It was closer now, someone grabbed her hands, rubbing their thumb into her palm as they spoke to her, but Catra couldn't hear it.

“Hey, hey I'm right here. Can you focus on my voice?” The person asked, squeezing her hands, before moving one palm up to her cheek, rubbing circles into it to get Catra to focus on her. The brunette looked up, Adora was kneeling in front of her, smiling with relief when Catra finally noticed she was there.

“Hi, just focus on my voice, okay?” Catra nodded mutely. “Good, can you breathe in and breathe out for me?” The brunette nodded again, doing as Adora requested, breathing in and out and finally feeling a sense of comfort.

Adora continued to rub her cheek, murmuring praises in her ear, eventually sitting down properly and pulling Catra onto her lap so that she could be closer. The brunette buried her face in Adora's neck, beyond the point where she could feel embarrassed by her blatant clinginess. She just needed comfort and Adora was providing her that, she was way past the point of critical thinking.

“You're okay…” Adora whispered, moving both hands to wrap around Catra's waist. She didn't mind how Catra had made herself a home on her lap, in fact, she seemed happy about it. She continued to pet Catra's back, mumbling about how Catra could stay like this as long as she wanted.

Eventually, she managed to calm down, recovering from her panic enough to realise that she's okay, that she was safe, and more importantly, that she was *alive*. It was only then that she realised that she was on Adora's lap, head tucked in her neck like she was kitten. She released a flustered whimper and pulled away, pushing a little too hard and landing on her back on the grass.

“Are you okay!?” Adora asked, moving closer to Catra like *that* wasn't the reason Catra panicked in the first place. The Princess ended up straddling Catra's hips and leaning closer, close enough for her to smell the subtle perfume she was wearing. She blushed furiously, pushing Adora off her.

“I'm fine!” She hissed, her tail swishing back and forth. “It was just a nightmare. I have a lot of those.”

“Do you want to talk about it? I'm a good listener.” Adora suggested, smiling encouragingly at Catra.

“No!” Goodness, Catra didn't need to get any closer to Adora. What she already saw was aggravating, she didn't need the princess to see any more of her issues.

Adora didn't push, she nodded at Catra's refusal just as Melog launched themself at her, tail wagging eagerly at the sight of Adora.

“*Hi*!” They squealed, licking Adora's face and neck. The Princess giggled, immediately reaching up to pet their ears and face. Melog leaned into it, though they did tilt their face to sniff the tips of Adora's nails.

“I was taking a walk in the forest and got us some food…” Adora said, pointing at the fire where she'd been cooking a small bird and some eggs.

“You didn't have to do that… Lord Prime packed us food…” Catra pointed out, because Adora had no reason to go out of her way like that for herself and Melog. It was just a waste of her energy.

“I know, I wanted to. I mean you did save me, doesn't matter if someone sent you to do it.” Adora responded with a simple shrug. “Now come on, after that nightmare, I think you need the food.”

Catra didn't argue with her, not when she was starving and emotionally drained from that nightmare. She ate without any complaints, the food was amazing, Adora was a good cook. After their food, the three of packed of the camp and loaded it onto the cart in preparation for their long journey. In reality, it wasn't as long she claimed it was, but when she was spending it with Adora who was making her heart feel all weak, it might as well be a year long journey.

She was not ready for this.

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

Ever since Adora comforted her the day before, Catra had avoided speaking to her. Their cart ride had been silent, and Catra only answered with the bare minimum when Adora asked her anything.

The blonde was annoyed by it. Had she done something? Did she comfort her wrong? She'll admit, she's not met a lot of people in her life, she was a sheltered child, and then she was locked up in a tower, the only people she’d known were her aunt, uncle, her cousin and her best friend. Maybe she did something wrong and didn't realise it.

It would be easier to figure out what went wrong if Catra *spoke to her* though! But no, the brunette wasn't talking to her except for the bare minimum.

Adora was sick of this. She was sick of this *silence*. She wanted to know what she did wrong.

They'd stopped briefly for a lunch break, Catra had walked aside to wash her hands in a nearby pond, and Adora decided now would be a good time to confront her. The blonde told Melog to take their time in finishing their food, informing them that they just wanted to go and talk to Catra about something, before following the brunette to the pond.

Catra was kneeling next to the ground, scrubbing her hand with a focused look, jumping in surprise when Adora came to stand beside her.

“Is something wrong, princess?” She asked, her tail swaying behind her as she got up and dusted off her clothes.

“Yeah. You've been ignoring me.” *Okay maybe we should’ve eased Catra into the conversation*. Unfortunately, Adora was never a subtle person.

“Ignori- I'm *not* ignoring you.” The brunette hissed, her ears drooping slightly.

“You are! You've been ignoring me since yesterday morning after I comforted you from that nightmare, and now you won't even *look* at me!”

“Not everyone talks as much as you do, that's not ignoring, princess, that's just people enjoying silence.” Catra responded, her tone condescending in a way Adora *hated*.

“Just because I grew up sheltered and then in a tower doesn't mean I can't tell the difference! At least tell me what I did wrong!” They were yelling now, if she wasn't careful Melog might get worried, but at that moment Adora couldn't care. She was furious with Catra, she just wanted to know what she'd done wrong.

“I don’t owe you *anything*, princess. You’re not my friend, you’re just a **job** to me!”

The tension that filled the clearing was so thick, Adora could cut it with a knife. Those words hit a chord in the blonde's heart that she didn't even know she had. She clenched her fists and straightened her back.

Catra *finally* registered the words that came out of her mouth, and to her credit, seemed to feel extremely guilty for what she said. “Adora-” She tried to say but the blonde cut her off.

“Come then, we must be on our way. Can't waste any time, my fianceé is waiting for me.” Adora responded in a quiet, posh voice she reserved for guests. Catra didn't portray, moving foward to lead Adora back to camp when an arrow whizzed through the sky and struck her in the shoulder.

Catra fell to the ground, screaming as she clutched her shoulder and the arrow that had dug itself into her. Without a thought Adora fell to her side, pulling the brunette into her arms and looking around for the source of the mysterious arrow.

“Well look what we found right here~” Adora turned around, and out of the shadows, a large lizard hybrid sauntered over, grinning when he noticed who the arrow landed on.

“Wow, you caught some beautiful ladies there Lashor.” The man’s lackey jeered, licking his lips at the sight of her and Catra.

“Well *I* caught them.” Lashor said with pride. “So that means I get first preference with how I use them. I'll toss them off to everyone when I'm done. Everyone deserves a chance with them.” He walked over to them, stepping back in shock when Adora *growled* at them. Even Catra was startled by the sound.

“Don't you dare come near us.” Adora warned, standing up and moving herself between Lashor and Catra. With her heels, she was just a few inches shorter than him, and he didn't seem quite threatened by her.

“Or what? You'll hurt me with your itty-bitty hands?” He teased, his group immediately bursting into laughter after the insult. Without any warning, Adora jammed her knee into Lashor’s crotch, watching as the pathetic man doubled over in pain while clutching the area.

“Yes, actually.” Adora responded confidently, watching as the rest of his men began to surround her.

“Catra!” Melog exclaimed, running into the clearing and pouncing on the brunette. Knowing that Catra was safe, Adora turned her full attention to the rest of Lashor's men.

“Give me your worst, boys.”

The group launched themselves at Adora, weapons drawn and ready to give it their all. She pulled off her high heel and rammed into the heads of one of them, before driving her foot into another's face.

"Oh you little-" The third hybrid grabbed her by the waist and slammed her into the nearest tree. "Not so invincible now, are you?" He teased, the words ending in a gut wrenching scream when Adora dug her teeth into his neck, her fangs breaking into the skin, the sharp tang of blood hitting her mouth and dripping down her face when she pulled away.

The two remaining hybrids ran at her with their swords, and Adora picked up a sword to match from the man with the high heel in his head as she wiped the blood off her face like a good lady. She blocked the fourth one's sword with grace, choosing to be on the defensive for the first few moves, mimicking the ones her best friend Bow had taught her eleven years back when Angella informed her that she'd live alone, and he didn't want to send Adora away without a good few self defense classes.

When she found a moment of weakness, Adora lodged the sword into his stomach, pulling it out when she was sure he was dead before tossing the body onto the fifth and final member of the group. When the fifth one was down too, Adora drove the sword into his face, a clear message for the three remaining hybrids she'd left alive. Tail tucked in between their legs, they rushed into the forest, and Adora swore she heard one of them crying.

Adora immediately ran over to Catra, lightly shoving Melog out of the way to pull the brunette into her arms.

"She's hurt, she's bleeding! Oh god she's going to die!" Melog exclaimed, pacing back and forth while eyeing the arrow nervously.

"She's going to be *fine*. Do me a favour, go in the forest and look for a blue flower with red thorns. Okay?" Adora asked gently, smiling when Melog nodded and ran into the trees, mumbling the specifications under their breath.

"What's the flower supposed to do?" Catra mumbled, hissing when Adora grabbed the arrow.

"It's supposed to get rid of Melog." She responded with a shrug.

"Smart." Catra whined when Adora began to pull the arrow out slowly, digging her claws into her thighs and burying her face in Adora's waist.

"Shhh, you're doing amazing dearest…" Adora murmured softly, rubbing Catra's back as she slowly pulled the arrow out. Catra whimpered at that, tail swishing in anticipation. "You're so good for me, yes you are. Its almost out I promise."

Catra groaned in pain when the arrow finally left her. Adora tossed it aside and leaned down to press a kiss to the brunette's head. "You did so good, I'm so proud of you. Can you walk back to camp with me?" Catra nodded, letting Adora lift her up and help her back to their campsite.

She placed the brunette on the cart, turning her around slowly to observe the wound, before coming to the conclusion that she needed Catra's shirt off to understand how severe it was.

"Take your shirt off." Adora whispered, meeting Catra's eye with a stern look.

The brunette blushed, her tail hitting the wooden portion of the cart. "T-Take me out to dinner first princess…" She teased, and in any other circumstance Adora would've indulged her, but after the hurtful things that left her mouth, Adora simply rolled her eyes.

Catra did comply, slowly shrugging off her white button up, hissing in pain as she tossed it aside, leaving herself in just a bra. Adora blushed, scolding herself to focus on the task at hand, which was examining Catra's wound.

"Do you have a first aid kit?" Adora asked.

"It's in the ration bag. It's wrapped in a white paper with a plus sign on top." The brunette gestured to the mountain climbing bag Prime's soldiers packed for her. Adora grabbed the bag and pulled out the first aid kit, immediately working on dressing Catra's wound.

Catra, to her credit, was extremely cooperative throughout the entire thing. She stayed quiet, even when the wound burned because of the medicine Adora applied. She didn't move or hiss or growl, she allowed Adora to complete her task as efficiently as possible. Her silence, however, didn't last.

"That was new…" She suddenly murmured, watching Adora curiously.

"What was new?" Adora asked.

"Your fighting… I didn't know you could do that…"

*Oh. Right, she was supposed to be a damsel in distress.*

"Well, when you're trapped alone in a tower, you need to learn how to defend yourself." Adora said, shrugging like it was the most obvious thing.

"Then why did you need me? You could've escaped on your own."

Adora groaned, rubbing Catra's wound a little too hard because the brunette hissed in pain.

"Isn't it obvious?! I can't break my curse myself. My true love must find me, and the only way that can happen is if I *stay put*!" Catra flinched when Adora raised her voice, ears drooping visibly. "I can't keep living this curse, I want to be rid of it, so I waited for ten years in that tower hoping that they'd finally come my way and rescue me! Then *you* did, you rescued me, and I thought it was you but you were sent by some man so that I could be his bride. So I thought, at least, I could be your **friend**, but you keep pushing me away!"

Catra listened to her, her eyes not pulling away from Adora even for a moment. She didn't say a thing, and when the blonde finished, she looked over to the grass. She didn't defend herself, nor did she attack Adora with her words. She just… stared. Adora didn't go on either,

she kept focusing on cleaning the wound, and when she finished, she looked through the medkit for any bandages, and found none.

*How do I cover it up?* Adora looked around the bag to see if there was any spare piece of cloth she could use to cover it up, only to find nothing. *Great. There's absolutely nothing I can use-* Adora's eyes landed on her cape, and her eyes went wide with realisation. She grabbed the scissors from the bag and pulled her cape open to slice off a massive piece of it.

“What are you doing?!” Catra asked, watching Adora slice off her cape with horror.

“Finding a cloth to cover your wound with.” Adora responded casually, wrapping the cloth around Catra's shoulder.

“Adora… you didn't have to do that for me.” Catra whispered, watching Adora with an unreadable expression.

“I know… But you did save me. The least I could do is return the favour.”

Their eyes met, and despite everything, Adora still felt her heart pound against her chest. She looked away and grabbed Catra's shirt, cutting off the bloody sleeve and shoving the shirt back into her chest.

“Put it on, we must be on our way.” Adora ordered before going to the front of the cart to pack everything up.

Melog would return, blue flowers with red thorns being held up in the air by their magic, their tail wagging proudly at what they'd successfully found. Adora would pat them on the head and compliment them for their success, before the three of them would return to the cart and be on their way.

Catra didn't say much during the cart ride, and Adora hated the silence. At the same time, she didn't regret her words. The brunette finally knew how she felt, and it was good, it felt healing. Maybe Catra would finally apologise for hurting her, but Adora doubted it.

She was just a job to her after all.

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

Catra hated herself.

After her argument with Adora, and the fight with Lashor that left her shoulder scarred, she and Adora hadn't spoken a word unless it was necessary. Melog had began to pick up on the tension, and tried to diffuse it by making up jokes and stories, but it was like a wall had grown between them. It wasn't undeserved, after what Catra did, she wasn't surprised.

She was stuck between apologising and breaking the ice, and staying the way she was and letting Adora hate her. Catra felt so, so caught when Adora realised she'd been ignoring her. In her stupid, desperate attempt to keep some distance and not open up again, she'd pushed Adora so far away that she didn't know if she could fix it.

As she watched Adora set up their camp for the evening, Catra knew that at the very least, she needed to try.

“Adora?” The blonde looked over her shoulder, before immediately turning her attention back to the fire she was starting.

“I'm sorry.” *That* finally caught her attention. Adora looked back over her shoulder, her eyes wide while observing Catra like she was trying to figure out whether the brunette was messing with her.

“You were right, I was ignoring you, but it's not because of you. You hadn't done anything wrong, *I'm* the problem.” Catra fiddled with her hands, the words felt like they were being forced out of herself, but she kept going. “I sound like I'm making excuses, but I'm scared of letting people into my life, of letting them see me when I'm vulnerable. I've been in charge of everything, really, since I was kid, and the one time I let my guard down, I lost everyone I had. You saw me after that nightmare and I- I *panicked.* I didn't want you to see me like that, it felt like I was showing more than I needed to. I can't be open like that, I'm supposed to protect other people, but I think we've already established that you don't need my protection, princess.”

Adora didn't say anything for a minute, and Catra began to worry about how monumentally she must’ve messed up. She wouldn't have been surprised if Adora didn't forgive her, she’d been awful to her.

“I'm still mad…” Adora mumbled, tapping her knuckles on her thighs.

“I know. You have every right to be.” Catra responded, giving her a nervous smile.

“I wanted to be your friend, and you made that very hard…”

“I know. I'm sorry, I really am. You deserved better that that.” Catra extended a hand to her. “We could start again, if you want of course…”

Adora gave her a small smile and shook her hand, tucking some hair behind her ear. “I'd love that…”

Catra sat down next to Adora, the two of them cooking their dinner together while Melog ran around the clearing chasing after butterflies. Adora did most of the work considering the brunette’s shoulder wound, but the tension that had built in their relationship was melting and easing away, making way for something new, something fragile.

Eventually, they finished eating, the clearing was cleaned of their things and bags, the only thing still lit was the fire as they watched Melog playing in the distance with a fawn they found and made friends with.

“Would it be weird if I… asked about your nightmare?” Adora whispered, fiddling with the end of her dress while watching Catra nervously. The brunette didn't flinch at the question, she knew it was coming, she'd been preparing for it.

“No, it wouldn't. I knew you were going to ask…” Catra took in a breath, mentally preparing herself, before she began. “Nineteen years ago, the hybrid raid began all over Etheria, but you already know that. I was staying in Duloc with my family, and we were hit the hardest. The entire population of hybrids was wiped out in one night, except for me and nine other children. We managed to escape into the forest together, and since I was the oldest, I took charge and found us a small cave deep in the forests.

“For the first three days, we were too scared to leave the cave. We were starving, dehydrated, but we knew they were still looking for us. Eventually, we had to find food, so I decided to go out and hunt for the ten of us. We had a good routine going for three weeks. I would hunt for lunch, dinner and fetch water, and beyond that we wouldn't leave the cave. One night, we let our guard down, we made too much noise, and the next day while I was gathering food I…”

*“We found the little brats!”*

*Catra ran into a bush, the corpse of the fawn in her arms, staining her body in blood as she watched the soldiers barge into the cave, swords drawn. Screams filled the forest, followed by the sounds of ripping flesh. The soldiers didn't hold back, and by the time Catra felt safe enough to enter the cave, she couldn't recognise the faces of those corpses that were once her friends.*

An arm wrapped around her waist, pulling Catra's head onto the Princess's shoulder. Only when her face rubbed into Adora's dress did Catra realise she'd started crying. She gasped for air, wiping her face to try and calm down.

“We didn't have anyone by that point, our families were dead. I was the one to dig their grave and bury their bodies… it was the least I could do after messing up like that.”

“You didn't mess up.”

The words were so sudden. Catra looked up and gave Adora a confused look. “What?”

“It wasn't your fault. You were just a child, you did the best you could for them.” Adora insisted, rubbing her hand against Catra's waist.

“I still let them die, I should've gone and helped!”

“If you had gone and helped, you would've been dead too. This **wasn't** your fault, you could've done nothing to stop it. It's the fault of those men who decided that hybrids didn't deserve to live, when they built this planet and their lives the same way humans did.”

Catra had said those words many times in her life, maybe in different ways, but the meaning never changed. Yet, for some reason, when Adora said it, butterflies began to erupt in her stomach. Once again, she found herself in awe of this girl who’d waited ten years for someone to break her curse, despite being able to save herself, who had kindness for everyone, but pushed it all aside when faced with injustice. Somehow, Adora, who'd spent her whole life locked up with her family, and the alone, understood more about the world than people who were in charge of ruling.

This girl, *wow*, she found new ways to draw Catra in.

“I couldn't have said it better, princess…” Catra said, because that's all her brain could come up with.

“I just think you should cut yourself some slack. You were just a child. You shouldn't feel so much guilt over something that wasn't your fault in the first place.” Adora squeezed Catra's waist, smiling gently at the feline. “Will you promise me something?”

“What princess?”

“Can you be nicer to yourself? You're a brave, wonderful woman who deserves everything nice that the world has to offer. Can you promise to give yourself that love?”

In their world, a hybrid would never find such kindness, Adora was the exception to the norm. Yet, Catra couldn't find it in herself to admit that to the sweet smiling princess.

“I promise, Adora. As long as you promise to never let someone protect you, not when you can defend yourself. Be your *own* knight…”

Adora grinned at that. “You've got a deal.”

They stayed cuddled up together for a long time, until the sun began to set and Adora decided she wanted to get some rest. She called Melog over and gave them some quick kisses before getting up to enter the cave they'd found. At the last moment, she turned around to face Catra with an oddly sentimental expression.

“You'll still be here in the morning when I get up, right?” She asked, her voice quiet and vulnerable.

Catra chuckled, giving the blonde an expression that gave away how blatantly enamoured she was. “Where am I going to go princess?”

“Just answer the question!” Adora whispered, blushing furiously and pouting.

She wanted to tease her some more, but Adora seemed like she needed this, so Catra indulged her. “I'll be here princess… don't worry.”

Seemingly satisfied, Adora retreated to her cave to rest after a tiresome day.

“*Oooh*!” Melog cooed from behind, eyes sparkling while their tail wagged mischievously.

“What, Melog?” Catra asked, giving them an annoyed expression.

“You’re *in love with her*!” Her hands hadn't moved that fast in her life, they immediately clamped around Melog's mouth, looking over her shoulder to see if Adora came out.

“What makes you say *that*?” She hissed. “I’m **not** in love with her.”

“You are.” Melog mumbled. “You were looking at her as though she hung the moon, and you would do *anything* for her.”

“I- I was *not*.” Catra whined pathetically, heart hammering against her chest.

“Liar liar, pants on *fire*!” Melog sang like the cheeky little thing they were. Catra grabbed the bag and smacked the feline harmlessly with it.

“Go to sleep, idiot…” She mumbled.

“Yes yes, I'll leave you to your dreams of your princess~” Melog skipped off with a bright smile, curling up in their spot next to the warmth of the fire.

Everyone fell asleep pretty quickly, but Catra remained awake for a long time, listening to the singing of the cicadas while watching the sun disappear and make way for the moon, Melog's and Adora's words running through her mind in an unstoppable loop.

She revisited every conversation she had throughout the day, trying to come up with excuses for her reactions, words and her actions. She was just being nice, she was helping, she was being a friend, but deep down, she knew she was lying to herself. Catra knew why she did everything, she knew, but she didn't want to admit it.

Admitting it meant that she'd fallen in love with Princess Adora, the last person she could fall in love with because she was engaged to Lord Prime and Catra could never have her the way she wanted.

Catra turned on her side and hugged herself tightly, trying not to look at the cave in which Adora was sleeping. She felt pathetic, it hadn't even been three days since they'd started travelling to Duloc, and somehow Adora had managed to charm her way into her heart like it was *nothing*. It wasn't fair, Adora didn't get to mess her feelings up like that, only to turn around and marry someone as soon as this trip was over.

She couldn't do anything now. Catra could be as angry as she wanted, but in the end she would've stayed by Adora’s side even if her heart broke at the sight of Adora loving and being loved by someone who wasn't her. She would move mountains for her love, even if her own arms ached, she would've planted and gifted roses even if the ones in her room wilted away.

Catra would give her life for Adora if it meant she could be happy. She could be angry, but it was all a lie. The brunette would accept anything Adora gave her.

*Mother, father, I am so, so screwed. Give me the strength to move past this so that I may save the hybrids living in my cabin from this madness.*

She never knew if her parents ever got her prayers, but it always felt good, and right now, she needed this more than anything. As she drifted into a restless sleep, she hoped that everything would work out, and she'd be able to move on from her feelings for Adora.

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

# Chapter 5: Five

Chapter Notes

> thank you to my beta reader Lesbian Simp for writing the fairy tale Adora tells in this chapter!

“I see a Secretary Bird!”

Adora pointed in the forest, Catra followed her arm until she noticed the elegant bird she was point at.

“Now I'm at 172, while you're at 165!” Adora cheered proudly, tossing Catra a playful smile. What Adora didn't know was that Catra had purposefully missed a good number of birds so that the Princess could overtake her. Seeing her happy made Catra dizzy with joy. Melog knew what she was doing, and had begun teasing her at night after Adora went to bed.

“You've been doing good, princess. I may have underestimated your bird knowledge.” Catra said honestly. Adora was a bright woman, quick on her feet and able to match Catra's energy with ease. It was the kind of dynamic that Catra had craved from her friendships and relationships. Adora was her perfect girl in every way.

“They left me alone in a tower for ten years with a huge library. I had nothing to do other than to work through every book.” Adora responded with a shrug, before resting her head on Catra's shoulder with a sweet smile that had the brunette melting.

“Why don't we take a break from this game? I fear you've bruised my ego.” Catra whined dramatically, looking away and sighing like a lovesick fool. Adora giggled at the performance, her hand reaching out to tickle Catra's side so that the brunette would glance over at her again.

“Do you want me to nurse you back to health? It might be more fun now that we aren't arguing, you know I'll take care *good* care of you.” The Princess teased, batting her eyelashes flirtatiously at Catra. The brunette blushed furiously, gulping quietly as she processed the words.

*Goodness she doesn't mean it like that!*

“I would love to have a princess tend to me, but I assure you, I can take care of myself.” She assured, turning her attention back to the horses so that Adora wouldn't notice her flustered state.

“If you say so…” Adora mumbled into her ear, before tucking her face into Catra's neck, arms wrapped around her waist.

“Why don't you tell me another story? I like listening to you narrate…” Adora loved to narrate the stories she read, she would get into the role and always had Catra immersed in the narrative in under five minutes. Over the last four days of travel, her retelling of *The Juniper Tree* had been Catra's favorite. She simply adored dark fairytales, and listening to Adora's soothing voice somehow made it better.

“Oh! Sure… I'll… I'll tell you a story my father told me when I was young.”

Catra froze. Over the last week, Adora had never once spoken about her parents. All she knew was that they were dead, and that her aunt and uncle, the rulers of Brightmoon were her legal guardians. Catra had mentally decided that her family, and her curse, were probably sore subjects Adora didn't like, which was why Adora never spoke about it. She seemed to open up a little now, and Catra didn't want to turn it down.

“Tell me…” Catra whispered affectionately, pressing her forehead against Adora's hair. The Princess giggled, before clearing her throat to begin.

“There once was a magicat mother living in a cabin with her 7 kittens. One day she needed to go out of the house to do some grocery shopping and left the kids in charge of the house. She had told them to not open the door for anyone but her, in the hopes that they would listen to her. Unknown to her a hunter was lurking around the woods, hoping to catch some magicats for their fur.

“When the mom was gone he knocked on the door, telling the children to open. But the kittens were smarter than that, they saw that he was not their mother and kept the door shut. A while later the hunter returned wearing a dress and trying to copy the mother's high pitched voice. They couldn't see nor hear the difference through the foggy window and let him in.”

Catra couldn't shake the feeling that she'd heard this story before, something about the seven kittens and the wolf felt familiar in her mind, and it took a minute for her to finally realised where she'd heard it.

*“For goodness sake Anthony!” Mrs.Violet exclaimed, turning around to glare at her son, before giving her daughter a worried look. Daphne was curled up in Catra's arms, shaking and whimpering, clearly terrified, while the brunette was completely unphased by the story.*

*“I **told** you not to tell that story to other children! I never should've let Edmund read it to you as a bedtime story. Your father is going to get it from me!”*

Oh my god. It was a **magicat fairy tale**.

“He pulled out his gun and threatened them with it, saying that if they wouldn't come with him he'd shoot them then and there. 6 magicat children were taken by the hunter. He thought he had captured them all, but sitting on top of the old grandfather clock was the youngest of them all. Benjamin.

“When his mom returned she found him crying in his hiding spot. The mother, not one for bull crap and most certainly not one to be messed with, reassured him that everything would be alright.

“They used their hightened senses to track down the hunter, carrying nothing but a thick rope. There they found him, sleeping next to a well with the other kits bound to each other.

“Slowly they crept up on him, light on their paws and controlling their breathing. Benjamin brought a nearby boulder closer to his mother, who on her end tied one end of the rope to the boulder and the other to the hunter's ankle. Slowly the hunter awakened, but it was already too late. The boulder was dumped into the well, soon followed by the evil man.

“With their sharp claws they managed to rid the magicat children of the rope, managing to get all of them home safe and sound.”

By the time Adora finished, Catra was reeling with confusion, her questions beginning and ending with how Adora, a ***human*** *princess*, knew a magicat fairytale. Fairytale books were notoriously written only by humans, and there was only one hybrid writer, Catherine Reddy, who had taken note of all the fairytales in hybrid culture, but those copies were destroyed after the raid nineteen years ago.

Only one copy was left, and that copy was with Catra, part of her mother’s collection.

“Hey, Adora. Your father told you this story? How did he learn it?” Catra asked curiously. Melog lifted their head to see the conversation as well.

“He said he learnt it from his parents, I think…” Adora responded, moving her hand down to play with Catra's tail, petting the fluffy appendage absentmindedly.

“That's a magicat fairy tale, how does he know it?”

Adora paused for a few minutes, opening and closing her mouth while staring at the grass with wide eyes. She didn't say anything, and Catra began to worry whether she'd touched a nerve with that question.

“He was involved with a lot of hybrids, he was a protector. Maybe his parents were too and that's where they heard it from.” Adora responded, and honestly it was the most bare minimum answer she could've given. It was enough to make Catra suspicious. Did this… have anything to do with her curse? Catra didn't know anything about what her curse actually did to her, only that it could only be broken by true love's kiss.

Maybe she should ask about it, can't hurt right?

“Does it… have anything to do with your curse?” Catra asked cautiously. Adora lifted her head and glared at the brunette.

“What?! My father’s involvement with hybrids? Of course not.” Adora insisted, crossing her arms over her chest.

“A lot of us learnt sorcery! And we loved to hold grudges, it could be a possibility is all I'm saying.” It fell on deaf ears, Adora huffed and rolled her eyes, before she pulled away from their embrace.

“You do not know my father, he was a kind, pious man. He never would've made enemies. Now can we leave this topic? I don't like discussing my curse.” She fiddled with her dress and began searching the trees for more birds, and Catra hummed in response.

Her father was a touchy subject, but Catra understood what that felt like. She didn't want to start another argument, not on their last day together.

“Ooh! Look over there! A Raggiana!” Adora grinned and pointed to a gorgeous bird sitting on a branch.

“Good job princess, you're at 173 now.”

“I know, I'm amazing at this game.” The Princess shrugged proudly.

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

The forest was growing less dense. It was a slow change, but Catra had been looking out for that sign ever since she began to smell those familiar scents of home. As soon as the trees began to reduce, dread began to pool in her gut.

They were reaching Duloc.

Soon, Catra would have to ride into the city and into the palace and hand Adora over to Lord Prime, even though he didn't deserve a woman so perfect, not when he didn't even put an ounce of work into rescuing her from her tower.

It didn't take long for Adora to notice that the forest was clearing and making way for a proper path. She abandoned her quest to search for birds, turning around to face the path they were on.

“Are we getting close to Duloc?” She asked, tapping her knuckles on her thighs.

“Yeah.” Catra responded simply, watching the road so that the Princess wouldn't notice her disappointment of having to let Adora go.

*Goodness, you are pathetic. You've only known this girl for a week and you're already attached.*

Finally, they left the forest completely and entered a small clearing. It was completely empty except for an abandoned hut. It opened into a cliff and out in the distance, Catra could see the massive Palace of Duloc stretching out into the clouds, just like the last time she'd seen it.

*Wow…* She thought. *We've come a long way.*

Adora was motionless. She didn't react in any way, all she did was stare at the palace with an unreadable expression, a mixture of excitement and dread.

“That's where I'll stay?” She asked quietly.

“Yeah.” Catra nodded, watching Adora with a worried look. The Princess’s excitement was changing into a look of utter panic, her leg began to bounce up and down as she watched the castle with a wide eyed look.

“I'm not sure… if I'm ready to meet him today.” The Princess admitted, hugging herself tightly. “Do we have to go to the palace today?”

“No. If you need a day to prepare, you deserve that.” Catra stretched out her hand to squeeze Adora's. “You can rest in that hut, it's so much better than those caves you've been sleeping in. You don't have to force yourself to do anything, okay?”

Adora nodded gratefully, and they parked the cart near the hut. Catra pulled out some food for the horses, while Adora worked on getting a fire started.

You could never get Catra to admit this, but she was so relieved that Adora asked for an evening to prepare herself before they decided to venture into Duloc. Catra wasn't ready to watch Adora get married to someone who wasn't her, it made her heart scream. At least she'd get an extra night to pretend that Adora was hers.

They'd run out of food to have dinner, Prime’s soldiers had only packed the essentials for the trip and nothing extra. It wasn't a problem for Catra, she decided to go into the forest and hunt a deer for the three of them to share.

When she returned, she found Melog curled up in Adora's lap while the Princess sung a lullaby for them. When Adora's eyes met hers, the Princess's expression into a soft, affectionate look. It was just enough to make Catra question her true intentions behind making them wait before going into Duloc.

Maybe, just maybe, Adora was also reluctant to let Catra go, maybe she wanted Catra as her own for one more day too. It was a crazy, unrealistic thought, but at the moment it seemed so real. Maybe Adora loved her too.

It made her think of a time in the far future. She woke up in her bed at her cabin with Adora in her arms. They made breakfast together, giggling and shoving each other in the kitchen. They relaxed in the river while taking a shower together, before curling up on Catra's couch, books propped on their laps with mugs of coffee on the table. Melog would run into their home, knock all of her decorations off the walls before getting on the couch with them so that they could read along with the two of them. It was nothing special, it was her normal routine, but she was no longer alone, she had Adora and Melog, and maybe Opie too.

It was an unrealistic wish, one that even a genie wouldn't be able to grant, but as she cooked the deer over the fire, watching Adora and Melog play together out in the distance, it seemed like Catra could reach out and touch it.

Maybe, just maybe, it wasn't a distant wish.

“Catra! I caught a squirrel!” Melog cheered, before picking up the dead squirrel in their mouth and running over to her, Adora hot on their heels. They dropped the squirrel next to Catra, their tail wagging excitedly while Adora sat down next to Catra's other side.

“You want me to cook it up for you with the deer?” Catra offered, to which Melog immediately nodded, resting their head in their lap while Catra begins cooking that as well. Adora joined the cuddle puddle as well, tucking her head into Catra's neck, and it was peaceful, and it was everything the brunette wanted.

“I've not said anything this week about your cooking, and that's a *crime*.” Adora said suddenly while they ate. “You're so good at this.”

“Well when you grow up alone and on the run, you get quite good at it.” Catra responded with a shrug, acting way more casual than usual to cover how flustered she was.

“I'll miss your cooking so much, since I'll be dining differently tomorrow…” Adora glanced over at the palace with a look akin to regret.

“Well after the marriage, when you're settled, you can come visit my cabin in Elberon. I can cook so many things for you, like brownies, soups. My mom's cinnamon roll recipe is still tucked away in the kitchen cabinets. Mama Laya was an amazing baker.” Adora looked over her shoulder as Catra began to ramble, gazing at the brunette with a look that had her melting. It wasn't fair that Adora can reduce her into a puddle so easily.

“I would love that… I'll probably need the break from being Queen.” She placed her empty plate aside and laid down to watch the sky. “I thought about it a lot, being a queen, being royalty. I can't believe it's here now…”

Catra laid down beside her, her tail smacking the grass beneath her. “Yeah… I get it. Are… you excited?”

“Honestly? No. I'm more excited to have my curse broken, but being married to someone I haven't even met? I'm not excited for it… but at least I'll have my future and life set for me, and my aunt would rejoice the wondrous match.”

Adora didn't seem as excited at the prospect of marriage as everyone else in her life, and Catra couldn't blame her. Marrying someone she barely knew seemed like a recipe for disaster.

“Well, I'll be here for you. My cabin doors are always open for you, feel free to visit any time, I'm not going anywhere.” Catra squeezed Adora's hand. The Princess turned her head to smile at the brunette, and moment fell silent.

For a second, they just stared at each other, before Catra's eyes dipped down to glance at Adora's lips. When the Princess noticed, she began to blush, gulping quietly before getting up and running her hand through her hair.

“I should go set up my sleeping quarters…” She whispered, tucking some hair behind her ear.

“Oh. Right. Yeah. You should go do that.” Catra responded, getting up and watching Adora with concern. Adora grabbed her sleeping bag and blanket and entered the hut without looking back, almost like she was rushing inside.

*Oh. Oh god. Did I do something?*

Catra began to spiral faster than expected. She got up and began to pace back and forth in front of the fire.

*Why did I have to do that? You can go five minutes without looking at her lips you **idiot**!*

Did she make Adora uncomfortable? Is that why she ran away so fast? Just when things were going good for their friendship, she had to go and *ruin it again*.

She continued to catastrophize while Melog sat behind her, shaking their head at Catra knowing pretty well that Adora was doing the same thing.

This went on till nightfall, Catra had curled up on her side while picking at grass. Confusion was clouding her judgement, and in a moment of pure desperation, she got up.

“Melog!” She whispered, shaking the feline awake.

“Ughh… what?” Melog groaned, rolling around onto their back, exposing their stomach to the wind.

“I'm going to find some flowers to apologise to Adora with. I can't end out last night together like this.” Catra informed them, ignoring their irritated look.

“Sure whatever, leave me alone, I’m *sleeping*.” They complained, to which Catra rolled her eyes. She got up and went down the clearing and into the forest. She'd seen some hibiscus flowers down the road, Adora will like those. Hopefully she'll like her apology too.

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

After Catra rudely woke them up inform them of her plan to apologise to Adora, Melog could not go back to sleep, and it left them in a sour mood. They tossed and turned, but no matter how hard they tried, they could not return to sleep.

Melog groaned and got up, shaking our their fur before looking around the clearing. They were still alone, Catra hadn't returned from her trip to grab flowers for Adora, which meant that they couldn't cuddle with her. They turned their attention to the hut Adora was currently sleeping in. Maybe they could blackmail her into cuddling with them, maybe into singing them a lullaby too.

Plan established, Melog walked over to Adora's hut and pushed the door open. Despite seeming small, the hut was two stories big. Melog began to sniff the ground in search of Adora, tail swaying behind them.

“Adora?” They called out, but received no response. They released a frustrated groan and began to search for any sign of Adora. They pushed a bunch of boxes out of the way and found Adora's sleeping bag, but it was completely untouched. Adora hadn't slept in it at all.

*Where did she go?*

A chair scratched against the ground. Melog jumped and looked up at the second floor. The chair was dragged across the floor, before the person upstairs, probably Adora, then walked across the floor to grab something else. Suddenly, everything went crashing to the floor, the chair toppled over and Adora fell on the ground.

"*Shit*! You **idiot**…" Adora cursed.

*Found her.*

Melog ran over to the steps and went upstairs to the second floor. The whole place was a mess, plates and dusty books were scattered across the ground. The chair was on the ground, the blanket thrown on top of it. That's when Melog's attention shifted to something else.

The whole room smelt **wrong**, it was Adora's scent, but there was something stronger mixed with it. Her scent, Melog realised, was similar to Catra's now.

"Melog?! What are you doing here?"

The feline turned around to find Adora standing there. Wait, this girl can't be Adora, she looked nothing like the princess.

The blonde woman in question was a young magicat with her blonde hair pushed into a bun, her bright blue eyes glowing in the dim light of the room. She had her arms wrapped around herself in a self protective pose, and she was watching Melog with a worried look.

"Adora…?" Melog mumbled, watching the woman apprehensively. The woman sounded like Adora, smelt (kind of) like Adora, yet it wasn't the woman Melog was used to.

"Oh dear, I was hoping you wouldn't see me like this." Adora buried her face in her hands, shaking her head angrily. "I shouldn't have made so much noise. Did Catra hear me?"

"No she went on a walk." Melog responded, watching Adora as she paced across the floor.

"Oh thank goodness. Now, I need you to leave the hut and act like this never happened. Okay?" Adora grabbed the books that she'd dropped, placing them in the dusty bookshelf she'd taken them from, before working on setting the chair right.

"Wait! You can't send me away without answering my questions!" Melog insisted, running circles around Adora's legs.

"I'm not answering questions about this. Now leave me alone." She responded, her voice dipping lower until the blonde was growling.

"Is this your curse? You turn into a magicat at night? Is that why I've never seen you like this, because you hide at night?" *No wonder she insisted on sleeping away from us. No one would willingly sleep in those decrepit caves.*

"Yes. I turn into this fricking **monster** at night." Adora set everything right, before grabbing her blanket and going down the steps, Melog following close behind.

“You're not a monster, you're just a hybrid.” They added casually, confused why Adora would see herself like this.

“I'm not a normal hybrid. I only turn into *this* at night, like a werewolf…” The Princess tossed her blanket onto her sleeping bag, sighing quietly and sitting down on it.

“*By night one way, by day another. This shall be the norm, until you find true love's first kiss, and take love's true form.*” Adora recited, the words sounding practiced. Clearly, she'd thought about this curse a lot, which is fair, she spent ten years alone in a tower with nothing else to do.

Melog moved over to Adora, curling up beside the Princess and rested their head on her lap. “I'm sorry princess, it sounds awful.”

“It is, it's so *painful*.”

“How did you get it? This curse?” Melog asked curiously, their ears drooping when Adora closed her eyes to blink back tears. “If you don't mind answering, of course.”

“My mother, Princess Marlena of Brightmoon, ran away with my father, a commoner magicat, Randor. My aunt said this angered gods, and they cursed me to turn into this at night.” Adora responded, not understanding just how *insane* that answer sounded.

*You're telling me that her aunt convinced this poor girl that her genetics is a **curse**? What in the everloving HELL…*

“They consulted with a witch, Shadow Weaver, and she couldn't remove this curse. Instead, she created a failsafe, changing my curse so that I would be cured when I find my true love. So I just ensure that Lord Prime doesn't see this… *monster* until he kisses me.”

*This poor girl, she genuinely believes this beautiful side is a curse. What did they do to her?*

“That's why I ran from Catra when she wanted to kiss me. It triggered my transformation and I didn't want her to see me like this… Even though I really wanted to kiss her.” Adora covered her face with her hands and began to sob. “She would never want this… disgusting thing. She wants to pretty Princess Adora…”

“Hey! You're not disgusting! If anything, the disgusting one is Catra. She hasn't showered in two weeks.” Melog joked, and despite everything, Adora snorted, looking down at Melog with a tear stained face, a wobbly smile on her face.

“She's been travelling for two weeks, cut her some slack. Also *you* didn't shower in two weeks either. You aren't any better.” Adora ruffled Melog's head fondly.

“I know, I just wanted to see you smile.” That made Adora smile wider, leaning down to kiss Melog's head.

They sat in silence for a while, Melog purring in Adora's lap while the Princess lost herself in her thoughts. Melog recognised her expression immediately, she was thinking about Catra.

“You’re in love with her, aren't you?” Melog asked her.

Adora blushed, her tail wagging behind her. “W-Who?”

“Catra, *duh*. You're gone for her.”

The Princess huffed, but she didn't deny the accusation.

“Why are you marrying Lord Prime? You could be happy with Catra instead.” They pointed out, rubbing their head all over Adora's lap to scent mark her.

“Isn't it obvious? I need to fix myself! I can't continue to be like this!” Adora exclaimed. “I need to get rid of this *monster*.”

“You're not a monster, Adora. You're just a magicat…”

“No. No, I can't- I can't *control* her. Don't you see? Hybrids and princesses don't mix. That's why I can't be with Catra, I can only be perfect when I'm Lord Prime…” Adora responded, leaning against the wall and sighing quietly.

“Why don't you get it?!” Melog stood up, walking around to face Adora. “You're setting yourself up for eternal suffering right after you got your freedom! You're such an *idiot*, you know that? Catra is right there, she loves and adores you more than anyone else in this world. She'll give up everything just to make sure you're happy. It doesn't matter what you are, you could be a worm for all I care! Catra will still love and cherish you in every way you can imagine.”

Melog's speech left the princess speechless for a minute. Her ears drooped and she gulped quietly, eyes drifting down to the ground as she processed the feline's words.

“You've gone through so much, Adora. I think you need something good in your life. Let Catra give that to you.” They whispered, reducing in size so that Melog could curl up in Adora's lap.

“Okay. I'll try. I'll confess to her tomorrow, and tell her the truth about my curse.” Adora responded, running her hand through Melog's fur.

“Good.”

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

By the time Melog and Adora woke up, the sun had entered the sky and Adora's transformation had retreated her, leaving her a human girl once more. Weirdly, Catra hadn't come to wake them up, but maybe she'd slept off outside too.

Adora was the one to wake Melog up. “Come on, I'm going to talk to Catra.” She whispered excitedly, and that was enough to pull Melog out of their comfortable nest of blankets.

The two of them opened the door and went down the steps in front of the front door when Melog felt the ground shake slightly. They looked up and in the distance they could see a

group horses coming in their direction, Duloc's crest on their armor.

"Who are they?" Adora whispered hurriedly.

"Soldiers from Duloc!" Melog whined in response.

The soldiers stopped in front the hut, Lord Prime got off the largest horse and moved gracefully towards Adora.

"Ah there she is! My bride." He declared, cupping Adora's cheeks and giving the Princess a predatory grin.

"M-My Lord…" She mumbled, and much to Melog's dismay, Prime grinned wider.

"That picture did not do you justice." He mumbled, running a finger along the princess's chin, before hooking his nail underneath to lift her head up and move her head from one side to the other.

"Thank you, my Lord. That is very kind of you." Adora responded, shaking in Prime's grasp. Melog curled themselves around Adora, a soft growl escaping him. Prime's gaze went down towards the feline, and without missing a beat, he gave them a quick kick. Melog whined and curled in on themself, while Adora gasped and pulled away from Prime, falling to her knees and pulling Melog into a hug.

Prime was unphased the entire time, he turned to his men and instructed them to ready his horse to take Adora with him. The blonde's gaze hardened, and when she finally got up to face him, she was glaring. "How did you know we were here?" Adora demanded.

"My champion came to inform me!"

*His champion? Oh. Oh god.*

Melog pushed themself up glanced over to the cart, only to find one of the horses missing, trampled hibiscus flowers in the spot where it should have been. The noise of hoofs on the ground only made Melog's dread increase as they looked down the road to see Catra leading the horse to the clearing.

The betrayal on Adora's face was extremely evident, and it would've been a funny expression if it weren't for the fact that Melog was the most confused they'd ever been in their life.

"Catra, my champion, thank you for bringing my bride to me." Prime said to Catra, wrapping an arm around Adora's waist. "You may take the cart and horses back with you to your cabin in Elberon. Your end of the bargain will be fulfilled."

"I'm most grateful for your generosity, Lord Prime." Catra responded emotionlessly, not even tossing a glance in Adora's direction, even though Adora kept giving her desperate looks.

"Well would you like to say anything to your princess? You've been travelling together for one week~" Prime pushed Adora forward slightly, grinning like a cat that caught the canary at the two girls.

Catra gave a professional bow in front of Adora, a far cry from the woman who had promised Adora that they'd be friends long after all of this. “It's been an honor to have brought you to the kingdom of Duloc, your majesty. Thank you for granting me the opportunity.”

Adora's eyes watered, her lips trembled, yet somehow this brilliant woman still managed to hold herself together. “I’ve also been honored that I got to know and travel with you. Thank you.”

Prime tugged her over to his horse, apparently he'd had enough of their goodbyes, and helped Adora onto it, and with one final longing glance at Catra, she was whisked away to a future she didn't want.

Melog stomped over to Catra, glaring at the brunette as she packed her cart for the trip back to Elberon.

“Why did you do that?!” They yelled furiously.

“Because, like she said, hybrids and princesses aren't compatible.” Catra responded, not even glancing back at Melog.

*What? Why does she…? Oh. Wait. Shit!*

“Catra. Catra no- Catra you misunderstood her! She wasn't-”

“I think I understood what you both were saying **perfectly**! My, weren't you both having a wonderful time gossiping about me.” Catra tossed the twig Melog had been using as a chew toy at the feline. “Get out of my sight. I don't want to see you ever again!”

Melog whined, grabbing the twig and watching Catra drive the cart out of the clearing, once again alone in a world that wanted to stomp on them.

*Why did all this happen? It was going so good…*

They looked around the clearing, just yesterday, they were sitting next to the fire, cuddling like a family. Now, everyone had gone in different directions into lives none of them want. Why was this happening to them?

With nowhere else to go, Melog realised they only had once place left where they could be safe.

*I'm coming to you Opie… if you'll have me.*

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

# Chapter 6: Six

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When she reached her cabin, the sun was already beginning to set. The horses were exhausted and in desperate need of water and food, Catra hadn't stopped for a break, she wanted to get home as soon as possible.

As she entered the clearing surrounding her cabin, the first thing she saw was twenty trucks stamped with the logo of the *Soul Clinic For Hybrids*, a name that sent a shiver down her spine.

*That's a torture center for Hybrids!*

She jumped off her cart and ran over to the closest soldiers, pulling his arm with anger in her eyes.

“What are you doing?!” Catra yelled, skipping past all pleasantries the guard wished to engage in.

“We’re removing these Hybrids from your land, mistress.” The soldiers responded like it was the most normal thing. Catra flinched at the title. Prime had awarded the title for rescuing Adora and bringing her to him safe and sound. She didn't want it, she didn't feel worthy of it, but she didn't say anything against it.

“This was not what I asked for. I wanted them to be given homes, I wanted them away from humans. You're sending them to be *tortured*!” All the soldiers were flinching at the volume of her words.

*If I were another hybrid like them, I’d be dead.*

She wasn't. She was the Champion of Duloc, that's why they were sparing her.

“You return to work, Harley, I shall speak to Mistress Catra.” The captain stepped forward, dismissing the guard with a wave of his hand. When they were alone, his eyes drifted to Catra, the only guard who gazed at the brunette with actual respect and not contempt.

“Captain Hordak, what questions do you have regarding the process, Mistress?” He asked politely.

“This isn't what I asked for. Why are they moving them to the Soul Clinic?” She asked helplessly, looking around as all the Hybrids were loaded onto prisons designed as transport.

“Mistress, Lord Prime was never going to give you wanted. He simply wanted to know where they were, and when he found out, he had planned it all out.”

Maybe Catra was truly dumb. She was dumb to have trusted that her fellow Hybrids would be safe if she did something in return, but in the end, Prime got everything he wanted, his bride, and all the Hybrids, while Catra was alone in her cabin with no one but herself to blame.

Captain Hordak left her alone, and she watched as those people who trusted her were sent away to their own personal hell. None of them looked at her, why would they? She'd betrayed them, even though she'd never meant to. Everything Catra had done those two weeks were for them, she'd hoped that if she helped them, then she'd be able to forgive herself for never helping her nine friends, but her best was never enough.

Lonnie, Kyle, Rogelio, Scorpia and Entrapta were the last to be loaded into the trucks. The only one smiling was Entrapta as she rambled to Captain Hordak about an experiment she'd been running, but the others were staring at the ground. Scorpia had tears running down her face.

*What have I done…*

The trucks began to leave the clearing in a straight line, Catra watching until the very last one left with her friends, the people she was supposed to protect, the people she'd failed *again*. Only when she was completely alone did Catra go into her home.

Her bags fell to the floor and Catra followed right after. She landed on her knees and slammed her hands on the ground, an inhuman scream escaping her throat.

*When did everything go wrong?!*

Just yesterday, she was dreaming about a future for herself, Melog and Adora, today she'd lost not just her future, but the people she'd sworn she'd fight for till her dying breath. She'd betrayed them, and it was all because she'd chosen the wrong person to trust.

Catra dragged her claws across the floor, tears running down her face as she screamed and roared, crying for the life her friends would never enjoy, crying for the life she'd have to live knowing that the woman she'd loved never truly cared about her. What was worse was that Catra *still* loved her, and would still drop everything if it meant Adora would be happy.

She loved too much, that was her mistake, and now it was stealing her life, one breath at a time. *This is my karma*, she thought to herself. *This is for all the lives I ruined.*

She curled up on the floor, the frustration of the day pouring out of her, staining the carpet with her tears and her pain.

***No. No, I can't- I can't control her. Don't you see? Hybrids and princesses don't mix. That's why I can't be with Catra, I can only be perfect when I'm Lord Prime.***

*Why can't I be perfect for you?*

It took her many hours to rise from her depressed huddle on the floor. She began to put away her things, bursting into tears when a small thing reminded her of Melog and Adora. It was

killing her efficiency, so she decided to leave arranging for another day and take a shower. She grabbed her towel and soap and made her way to the river.

Removing the two weeks of grime, dirt and blood was *amazing* and refreshing, but it wasn't without its tears. It killed Catra to get rid of the cloth Adora had wrapped around her shoulder. It was like accepting her reality, and she wanted to remain delusional.

Somehow, she managed to collect herself enough to get dressed and come to her kitchen to cook. Prime had left three bags of groceries for her, filled with vegetables, meat, and breakfast foods. That was good, she was too exhausted to go out and hunt.

Her mind wasn't there as she cooked, she didn't want to think about her emotions, didn't want to think about Adora. She didn't want to think about how the blonde had single handedly stolen her heart by doing nothing but being herself, but was it really Adora Catra had fallen for? Was it a facade she'd put up to lie to Catra? She'll never know.

She didn't want to know, because she never wanted to see Adora ever again.

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

Palace life was exactly as Adora imagined. Restrictive. Professional. Cold.

The freedom she had from being with Catra and Melog was swiftly taken away. She was kept to a guest room beside Prime’s chambers. It took so much lying for Adora to convince Prime that she had a tradition in Brightmoon which didn't allow lovers to have sex until the marriage. He was frustrated about it, but much to Adora’s relief, he didn't push her.

That was how Adora ended up alone at night, roaming her room as her claws itched at the unfamiliar place. Normally she would scent her room, but she didn't feel safe doing that either, not when she craved the presence of someone else, a young magicat with bi-colored eyes.

The wedding was in three weeks. Everyday, her handmaid, Lily, would come with a group of seamstresses, taking her measurements and offering dresses for her to try on. Adora wasn't a particular person when it came to dresses, most of the time Lily would make the decision for her. It was hard for Adora to care when her heart simply wasn't in the marriage.

She knew where her heart was, it was in a little cabin in the forests of Elberon. But her heart had been rejected. No matter what she did, Catra always rejected her affection.

Beyond that, her handmaid would take her to the wedding hall to approve decorations, check the cusine and the wedding cake. It was mundane tasks that required no mental effort, and Adora appreciated the distractions, and she appreciated Lily for providing her with them.

Nothing could distract her at night. When she was in that form, everytime she looked in the mirror, she could see signs of the woman she loved in her ears and tail. It was torture, and all she wanted to do was smash the mirror so that she wouldn't have to face it anymore. She didn't, Adora didn't want to worry anyone. She decided to live with the pain, the anger, the suffering, because that was what the rest of her life was going to be.

Adora told herself that it would be worth it if Prime broke her curse, she'd be normal, she'd be human. Her aunt wouldn't have to worry about her anymore. It would be worth it, a life with this man would be worth it. She could handle the objectification, the possessiveness, the lack of control on her life.

That was a lie, but maybe if she told herself that a few hundred times, she'd start to believe it.

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

Opie hadn't expected to see them again, that much was obvious when Melog showed up at the palace. She accepted them with open arms though, and they entered a routine almost immediately.

It was obvious from the start how smitten Opie was with Melog, but the enormity only seemed to register when they began living together. Opie was devoted, she didn't allow Melog to do anything and always insisted on going out to hunt while Melog stayed inside and looked after their home. Maybe she enjoyed having a stay-at-home partner, as the humans called it. Melog didn't *mind*, but they didn't enjoy the fact that Opie did **everything**, she needed a break.

Melog didn't think about Adora and Catra at all. They frayed at the seams just imagining what the blonde was going through. Opie asked about Adora *constantly*, though, and Melog always gave her the most bare minimum answer. It was the only thing that frustrated her, Opie was always sweet but not knowing how her baby was didn't please her. Yet, she never pushed them for more, despite how much she *clearly* wanted to.

Life was good, Melog had everything they could want, a companion, food and shelter, and more importantly, *protection*. No one would dare to come near them, not when they had Opie for protection. That was more than what they'd ever wanted, and they cherished every moment of it.

One morning, Melog woke up earlier than usual to find Opie in the process of leaving for a hunt. They immediately got up, following their partner out of the room. Their footsteps were quiet, so it took a moment for Opie to realise they were following her.

"*Rest, my love*." She cooed, blocking the entrance before Melog could slip out.

"I want to help!" They whined in response, stomping a foot on the ground petulantly.

"*You do not have to. That is what I'm here for. Let me take care of you."* Opie leaned down, shoving her head into Melog's body to push them backwards.

"No, we take care of *each other*, this is an equal partnership! We hunt for each other, so you are going to let me go with you!" Melog yelled back, sitting down in front of Opie so that they could their point across.

Ophelia seemed *confused* by that prospect, tilting their head while staring at Melog. "*That does not make sense to me. I have always looked after my loved ones, my size has made it convenient for me. Why would you look after **me**? I do not need the help."*

“Why *wouldn’t* I look after you? We’re lovers, and in this partnership, we look after each other! Just because it’s *easier* for you to look after me, doesn’t mean I can’t do the same. Maybe I won’t *succeed*, but it’s the thought and effort that counts. I care about you, and I want to put in that effort.” Melog responded easily, smiling up at Opie brightly.

For a second, their lover didn’t respond, she seemed to be processing the answer. When she did, she leaned down to rub her face against Melog’s.

“*I guess that makes sense. I am not used to being looked after…*”

“I know, so let me do that for you. You deserve it…” They rubbed their small face against Opie’s, purring eagerly at the affection.

“*Okay. Come, let’s go hunt.*”

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

It was midnight, the entire palace was asleep, except for one person. Adora was seated on the railing of her open window, her hair flying in the wind as she watched the moon with a blank look.

She was exhausted, but her dreams wouldn’t let her sleep. Whenever her head hit the pillow, all she could think of was Catra, her easy smile, her cocky personality, and their final night together when Catra almost kissed her.

Adora thought about those *what if* scenarios. Would things have been different if they’d kissed, if Adora had found the courage to tell Catra how she felt? Would Catra have taken her away with her to her cabin, would they have spent the rest of their life as lovers?

Maybe it wouldn’t have lasted peacefully, maybe they’d have to spend their life running from Prime. He had a sense of entitlement to her, even though he was never the one who saved her. Maybe Catra and Adora would’ve never been free of him, but they wouldn’t have cared, because they would have had each other.

*Catra would’ve held her hand, squeezing it with a soft smile before leaning forward and kissing her. She wouldn’t care when the sun began to set and Adora turned into something uncontrollable, she would’ve cupped her cheeks and told her she was the most beautiful woman she had ever seen. Adora would’ve smiled through her worried tears, and kissed Catra again, and together under the moonlight, they would’ve made love to each other, giggling like two young lovers. Life would’ve been simple, Adora had never wanted to be royalty. It would’ve been everything she wanted because she had Catra.*

Adora didn’t have Catra, and now she would probably never get the chance. Soon, she’d be the Queen of Duloc, free from her curse for the rest of her life. She would never get to rule, Prime wanted to ensure she was with child by the year’s end. That was all she was to him, a way to ensure he was the King Of Duloc, and the mother of his children, because why would he bothered with *raising* them? That was Adora’s job.

She would disappear under the pressure of royal duties, just like how she'll disappear from Catra's memory. The feline would find a new partner soon, she was too beautiful not to. Her home would fill with the laughter of another woman who wasn't her, and slowly Catra wouldn't remember who Adora even was.

Adora, on the other hand, would never forget. From now until her death, she would never forget the feline. Catra was the love of her life, maybe not her true love, but who cares? Maybe in another universe, things would've been different, but this life wasn't for Adora. Her happiness meant nothing.

When Adora finally went to sleep, it was because she'd cried her heart out, and the exhaustion was too much to handle. Like every night, she wondered whether Catra thought of her the way she did, but she knew the feline didn't. If she did, Adora wouldn't be here.

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

**One Week Later**

"*I cannot believe I wasn't invited to the wedding.*"

Melog was tracking a squirrel outside the window Opie said that. They turned around, giving their lover a confused head tilt.

"Which wedding, my love?" They asked, before returning their gaze to that squirrel.

"*Adora and Catra's! What other wedding would I be referring to?*"

For a moment, Melog didn't respond. They still had no idea how they were going to explain the whole marriage situation to her.

"They wanted to keep it small, it was just them saying their vows." They lied, it would tide her over for the time being until Melog could tell her. Opie didn't seem convinced, and she made that very clear.

"*Adora always said she'd invite me, it was the one thing she stood by for the last ten years.*" She insisted, crossing her paws and glaring at Melog.

"Well I wasn't either. You don't see me complaining." Melog shot back in an annoyed tone. They hated talking about Adora and Catra, it was a sore spot, especially after the train wreck last day together.

Opie didn't respond, watching as Melog walked to the corner of the room and curled up on their blanket. They huffed when it didn't feel warm, standing up and scratching gently in order to heat it up.

*"You are lying to me.*"

Melog whipped around to find Opie glaring at them. "W-What?"

"*You are lying to me about Adora and Catra. You have been since you first came here. What are you covering up from me?*"

Their ears drooped as Opie stared them down. Melog had no idea what to say, but they knew there was point in lying to her anymore.

"Catra- Catra did not come to save Adora of her own free will. She… was sent by the King of Duloc, Lord Prime." Melog explained. "Lord Prime wanted to marry Adora, so Catra dropped Adora off at Duloc and returned home."

Opie snarled when Melog finished talking, making them whine and curl in on themself.

"*That's bullshit! I did not approve of this 'Lord Prime'. How dare he send someone else to do his work like a* ***coward****. He is not worthy of my Adora. Catra is! I chose* ***Catra****, that is the girl I chose for my Adora. I will not stand for this nonsense.*" Opie finished firmly, standing up and shaking out her fur before making her way to the steps of her room.

"What do you mean you *chose* Catra?" Melog asked, bounding over to Opie's feet.

"*Catra is her true love, I sensed it as soon as I laid my eyes on her*." Their lover responded.

*W-What?*

Catra and Adora were each other's true love. **Catra and Adora were each other's true loves!** Well of course they were, it made total sense, they were made for each other. They balanced each other out in a way only true love could, and now Adora was signing herself up to marry a man (who wasn't even worth her in the first place).

*Catra if you had just eavesdropped better we wouldn't be in this situation right now!*

Melog was with Opie on this one, they weren't standing for this nonsense.

"Then I guess we need to stage a rescue." Melog said to Opie with a grin, tail swaying eagerly. Opie grinned down at them, before nodding and leaning down so that they could climb onto her back.

"Take us to Catra's cabin first! I'll show you the way." They instructed, and for the first time in the last week, Melog felt a sense of hope bubble in their chest.

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

She was outside feeding the horses when Rosalind showed up. Catra ended up naming the female horse Storm, and the male one Swift Wind. That name had no particular relation whatsoever, Catra insisted as she left hay and water for them, no relation at all. She *hadn't* named the male one Swift Wind because Adora mentioned she'd had a unicorn plush of that same name, and had been so disappointed when her aunt hadn't allowed her to bring the plush with her to her tower.

Rosalind's quiet, familiar chirp had startled Catra, and she whipped around to find the raven seated on a branch with a note clutched in her mouth. She ran over to her and immediately

grabbed the note, rolling it open just as the bird demanded Catra for food. After feeding Rosalind, Catra sat down beneath a tree and began to read the note.

*I know you wish to free the hybrids from The Soul Clinic, and I wish to do the same. If you are okay with my assistance, we shall continue to correspond over letter. Rosalind knows where to find me.*

The letter wasn't signed, Catra had no idea who sent it. The smart thing was to ignore it, but a few days passed and Catra found herself corresponding with this mysterious person in every spare moment. She enjoyed it, especially now when nothing interested her anymore.

Catra couldn't get herself to do anything beyond eat, sleep and shower. Her free time was spent laying on her couch and staring at the ceiling, questioning her life choices.

It was pathetic, mooning over a girl who'd shown her that she didn't care in the worst way possible, yet Catra clung to those sweet moments they shared like a lifeline, wondering whether they could've been together if things were different, if Catra was a prince, or someone rich, or if she was human too. Corresponding with this mysterious person who wanted to save the Hybrids with her gave her a purpose in life.

Today was yet another day like that, but it also wasn't. It was the day they'd agreed on, when Catra would storm the clinic and free the hybrids. She finished her lunch, and decided to go outside and check on the hibiscus plant she'd begun to grow since she returned. The seed hadn't sprouted yet, but it was a matter of time. She wanted to make sure they were well taken care of before she left.

When she finished tending to them and began to pack up her supplies, she heard silent footsteps behind her, along with the crunching of grass. Catra sighed, turning around expecting to see one of her horses standing behind her. The last person she'd expected was Melog, glaring death at the brunette.

"I told you not to come back." Catra warned, picking up her watering can and her dirty gardening gloves before making her way to the door. "Don't you have a lover to return to?"

"I could ask you the same question." Melog responded in a sassy tone, following Catra with a determined expression.

"I'm not committed to **anyone**, I made a mistake getting attached to you and Adora. Trust me, I won't make it again." The brunette hissed, her tail swishing in irritation.

"*Honestly*! If you just get your head out of your butt, you'd realise you made a mistake in letting her go!" Catra rolled her eyes, standing in front of the door to block the entrance from Melog.

"I didn't make a mistake. You two were having a grand time making fun of me, I just cut the negative influences out of my life!" Catra growled, hands on her hips as she glared at Melog.

"*This* is your problem! You always see the worst in people that you never even try to give them a chance!"

“Can you blame me? The two of you were talking behind my back!”

“We *weren't*! If you’d stayed for five seconds you would've seen it! We **weren't talking about you**!”

The silence that filled the clearing spoke more than Melog and Catra. The brunette’s ears dropped, eyes wide as she processed the words that Melog threw at her.

“What- What do you mean…?”

“Catra, we were talking about someone else! We weren't taking about you. In fact, I was convincing Adora *to confess to you*! She was running out of the hut in the morning **looking for you** before the soldiers and Prime interrupted us!”

*Oh my god, I made a big mistake.*

“You're kidding…”

*What have I done?!*

“If you could've just waited instead of jumping to conclusions, Prime wouldn't have Adora right now!” Melog yelled, but their words were gibberish in her mind right now as Catra ran through everything she could remember from that night. She'd walked away from the hut as soon as she heard Adora say that like an *idiot*, all she could remember those words which had haunted her for the entire week.

*Adora, I'm so sorry.*

Why didn't she just listen to Melog? Why did she have to jump to the worst possibility and send Adora away with Prime? There was no way she could reach them now. At least, not without help.

“Is there something you want to say to me?” Melog probed, sitting down in front Catra expectantly.

“Melog, I am so sorry- I shouldn't have done that. You're right, I jump to the worst possibilities and I should've just asked you two…” Catra answered, every word genuine because she'd missed both of them like crazy, and now she missed Adora even more.

*I shouldn't have let you go. I promise I'll fight to have you back.*

“I forgive you. Now come on, what are you waiting for!? We should go and save Adora from that freak!” Melog grabbed Catra’s nightrobe with their teeth and began to tug, only for the brunette to shake her head.

“No no, we need to be smart with this Melog. Just the two of us and they'll overpower us. We need help.” She glanced at the sky, noticing that the sun was beginning to set. She had to leave now to rescue the hybrids. A plan began to form in her mind, a way to save those hybrids *and* save Adora, all at the same time.

“How fast can Opie get here?” Catra asked, grinning down at Melog. Almost like an answer, Opie emerged from the shadows of the trees, cooing in a low tone at Catra.

“What’s the plan?” Melog asked excitedly, tail wagging as she grinned at Catra.

“I’ll tell you on the way. Wait here, let me grab my things.”

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

The Soul Clinic was everything Catra imagined it to be. It looked like a block of steel with a few windows at its base. As Opie flew closer and closer to it, Catra's heart began to pound in her chest. If she could rescue the Hybrids safely from the facility, she'd feel safer storming Prime's castle. Strength in numbers right?

“Opie I want you to crash through the entrance okay?” Melog instructed, pointing their paw at where they wanted their lover to go. Opie mewled in response, reducing her size considerably so that she wouldn't destroy the entire building and kill the Hybrids, before descending to the ground and slamming her body straight into the wall with abandon.

The soldiers at the reception began to scream, all of them drawing their sword at Opie who snarled at them. Catra and Melog slid off her back, allowing Opie to chase after the soldiers in their path.

Catra and Melog ran up the steps, Opie leading the charge so that every soldier would clear their path. No one recognised Catra as stormed the building, she’d worn a black skintight suit complete with a black cloth to cover the lower half of her face.

The soldiers scattered as soon as they saw Opie, screaming and crying as soon the beast even *looked* in their direction. Melog also joined their lover, increasing in size and attacking all the soldiers who got a little too bold and aimed their weapons at Opie.

Catra had bigger fish to fry. She abandoned them to deal with the soldiers and began to search for the lever that would open all the metal doors at the same time. She remembered one of the soldiers mentioning it while she was watching them load all the Hybrids away.

It took her a few minutes to find a large door, protected by five bodyguards. They immediately drew their swords at Catra, only for Opie to step in last minute and tear them to shreds. Catra burst in, she didn't want to waste a second, panting quietly while her eyes scanned the room for what she needed.

There were a lot of buttons, but it didn't take long for her to find the lever she wanted. As she moved closer, she registered someone entering the room, the person then drawing their sword. Catra turned around, raising her hands when she realised that she recognised this soldier.

“Mistress Catra, I thought I'd be seeing you here.” Captain Hordak commented casually, twirling his sword in his hand.

“Nice to meet you too captain, now if you'll excuse me, I have work I need to do.” Catra walked backwards until she could feel the lever digging into her back.

“What a surprise, me too.” Hordak commented, following Catra until his hand grabbed the lever and dragged it down. The brunette gave him a shocked look, the last thing she expected was *help*, especially from one of Prime's soldiers.

“Entrapta, or any of those Hybrids for that matter, do not deserve to be treated like this.” Hordak pushed his sword back into his belt.

Catra grinned, even though Hordak couldn't see it due to her mask. “It was you, you were sending me those letters.” She whispered. “What made you change your mind? You were loyal to Lord Prime, one of his trusted generals…”

“Entrapta was a close friend of mine, before she was taken away by those generals for looking after Scorpia. I mentioned it before, they do not deserve such a fate, and I will not let them be subjected to it.” Hordak responded firmly. “Now come, I shall lead you out.”

The whole building had devolved into *chaos*. The bodies of soldiers were strewn everywhere as Hybrids and magical creatures ripped their limbs off. Some of the Hybrids had broke into the acquatic section and were running out with the sirens in their arms, yelling to their companions that they'd retrieved the fish.

Catra watched in awe as the Hybrids, hybrid protectors and magical creatures banded together to protect each other from their attackers, grabbing swords from the dead bodies and fighting the fire with an inferno the humans had never experienced. It was miraculous, and by the time the Hybrids managed to leave the building, none of the soldiers were alive.

“Everyone! Into the forest!” Catra ordered, pulling off her mask pointing at the thick forest behind the building. Everyone cheered when they realised their saviour was her, and they immediately ran into the forests, mumbling amongst themselves while glancing at her. Opie and Melog left the building covered in blood, laughing to each other like they hadn't just murdered an entire building’s worth of soldiers. Catra grinned and joined the Hybrids in the forest so that she could address them directly.

“Catra!” “You came back for us!” “Thank you thank you!”

Catra smiled affectionately at the Hybrids, watching as they jumped in joy at the prospect being free. “You guys don't have to thank me, I would've always returned for you guys.”

“I'll admit, I thought you'd sold us out.” Lonnie said, leaning against Rogelio with her arms crossed over her chest.

“I never lost faith in you Wildcat!” Scorpia declared, running forward and pulling Catra into a massive bearhug. The brunette wheezed, feelings like her ribs were being crushed with the strength Scorpia brought into the hug.

“Thanks Scorp…” Catra choked out, gasping for air as soon as Scorpia let her down. “Now that you guys are free, I need your help…”

“We need to crash a wedding!” Melog declared with a grin.

“A wedding? Who’s wedding?” Kyle asked, eyes wide as he glanced between Opie, Melog and Catra.

Lonnie grinned at the brunette. “It's Adora's, right?”

“What? How do you know?”

“It was so obvious from your letters that you'd fallen in love! You weren't even trying to hide it!” Lonnie responded without missing a beat. Catra blushed and looked away with a pout, rubbing her neck in an embarrassed manner. In her defense, she hasn't known she was being *this* obvious.

“Of course we’re in! Prime never deserved her in the first place.” Lonnie cheered, hands on her hips as she grinned at Catra. The rest of the hybrids also chimed in, jumping up and down and yelling eagerly.

“When is the wedding?” Melog asked Hordak, tail swaying behind them.

“In the next two days.” The former captain responded, keeping one hand wrapped around Entrapta’s shoulder. “I will say that the security will be ramped up since the hybrids broke out of the facility. We will have to tread with caution.”

“With our numbers, it won't be an issue, I assure you.” Catra added with a grin, the hybrids screaming once more at her confidence.

*Adora, I’m coming for you, I won't rest till you're happy.*

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

They'd planned this for two days. In between dodging Prime's soldiers, the *Desert Roses*, as Scorpia began to call them, planned their actions with careful scrutiny. In the end, they decided that the sirens would stay back at the lake with the teenage hybrids. Catra would take the adults and the magical creatures along to Duloc to take down the soldiers and provide a protective unit for Catra and Adora, Hordak assisting in providing all the weak spots that they could neutralize quickly.

“Are you nervous?” Melog asked, adjusting so that they could sit beside Catra as Opie flew them to Duloc. She’d increased to her maximum size so that she could fit as many hybrids and creatures on her back as possible, and right now they were only a few minutes away from reaching the palace of Duloc.

“I’m about to crash a wedding, confess and probably kidnap a woman of royalty. What do you think?” Catra asked, keeping her gaze focused on the trees, waiting to see when Duloc would show itself to her.

“It's not kidnapping if Adora wants it.” Melog pointed out.

“No, but Prime will definitely spin it as a kidnapping.” Catra shot back, ears going flat against her hair when Duloc’s palace appeared straight ahead.

*It's time.*

“Down there Opie!” Catra ordered, pointing at the palace. Opie growled in response and made a beeline towards the palace entrance, landing on the ground as the soldiers scattered like ants. The Desert Roses slid down from her back as Melog and Opie began yet another rampage on the street.

Lonnie, Kyle, Rogelio, Scorpia, Entrapta and Hordak joined Catra as she ran towards the palace entrance, ready to kick the door down when Scorpia pulled her back.

“Wildcat wait!” Scorpia whined, turning Catra around to face her.

“What?!” The brunette glanced between the group with a confused look.

“There's a line you have to wait for! The priest will say *And All those who object, speak now or forever hold your peace*, and **then** you'll kick down the doors and announce *I object*!” She answered, a bright smile on her face.

“You're kidding, this isn't some romance novel. I'm not doing that.”

“Yes you are. It's romantic, your girl will like that.” Lonnie added, grinning like a cat that caught the canary at her.

“Look, you love this girl don't you?”

“Yes, Scorpia.”

“You want to hold her? Please her? Promise her all the most beautiful things in the world?”

“If I didn't, we wouldn't be here in the first place! I’m not the type to risk the lives of my fellow Hybrids for a simple fling!”

“Then you *must* do it right for her! She will **swoon**!”

Clearly, there was no way around this. In the end, they decided to help Kyle reach the window high up the building so that he could report to Catra when she could go inside and object.

Scorpia pulled the young blonde onto her shoulders, trying not to move too much while Kyle slowly pushed on the window.

“Shit, it won't open!” Kyle whispered, glancing down at Lonnie with a worried look.

“As long as you can see what’s going on, we’re okay!” Lonnie responded, to which Kyle nodded and continued to look through the window.

“Wow! The whole town’s here for this!” Kyle exclaimed in fascination. Hordak groaned and facepalmed, while Catra shook her head with an annoyed sigh.

“He’s the king, of course the whole town’s going to be there.” Lonnie answered. “What else is going on?”

“They're at the altar! Oh wait oh wait- They’ve put on the rings! They're about to kiss!”

“Oh for the love of god!” Hordak, Rogelio and Lonnie were immediately at Catra's side as she shoved the doors aside and barged into the palace.

“*I object*!” She screamed, walking down the aisle as the three of them pulled out their weapons, ready to attack any of the soldiers who got to close to Catra. The villagers were aghast as Catra ran to the altar, but she couldn't care less. Her eyes were on Adora alone.

“You were not invited!” Prime exclaimed, grabbing Adora's hand tightly when Catra approached the two of them.

“Oh what a *travesty*! It's not like I didn't crash the wedding *anyway.*” She turned to Adora, grabbing the blonde’s free hand with a pleading look. “Adora I need to talk to you-”

“Oh so *now* you want to talk?!” Adora yelled back, pulling her hand away from Catra's. “It's a little too late for that! If you'll excuse me, I'm going to be married.”

“Adora I made a mistake when I let you go. You cannot marry that man! He’s only marrying you so he can be king,”

“Preposterous!” Prime cupped Adora's cheeks and forced her to look at him. “My love, we are only a kiss away from our happily ever after! You cannot listen to her of all people.”

Catra gently took Adora's hand again. “Princess, he isn't your true love.”

Adora pulled away from Prime's grip to look at her. “And what do *you* know about love?”

Catra’s eyes went wide, she gulped quietly as everyone's eyes landed on her. Prime's gaze lit up when he finally realised what was going on.

“My my! The magicat is in love with the princess! Is everyone hearing this?!” He began to laugh heartily, and the audience joined in, adding their own fake laughter just to please their lord.

Catra didn't care, her gaze remained fixed on Adora. “You don’t have to give me the time of day…” She whispered, probably looking at Adora as though she'd hung the moon. “I don’t deserve it, but please, just five minutes. Five minutes and then I’ll leave.” If she doesn’t tell Adora how she feels now, she will never get this chance ever again.

After a moment of silence, Adora nodded to the guards. They lowered their weapons as the princess turned to face her fully.

“Those two weeks that I spent with you, those were the best two weeks of my life. Everyone I ever met either screamed at the sight of me, or they ran away before I could ever introduce myself, but you, you looked at me like I was worth something, you made me see a side of myself I never even knew existed. Adora, you are a beautiful woman, both on the inside and on the outside. The world was so intent on breaking you down over and over again, but somehow you still smile and get back up, you walk it off like it's nothing. It's so admirable, I lose my breath at the very sight of you. I want to be more like you, I don't want to let the world’s view change how I treat myself and my feelings, so I'm starting with saying how I actually feel about you.” The feline went down on one knee, still holding Adora’s hand and smiling up at the blonde like the lovesick fool she was. “I’m not the prince or the knight you wanted, I can’t spoil you with riches or with the royal life you deserve, but if you gave me a chance, I promise that I’ll treat you like the princess you are, because I love you, I love you more than anything this world could ever offer to me.”

Adora was silent, eyes wide, one hand covering her mouth. Catra couldn’t tell if she was offended, happy, or just plain disgusted. The feline realised that right now, she couldn’t find it in herself to care.

“You don’t have to say yes, I won’t feel offended if you don’t. I just couldn’t let you go until you heard me say it.” Catra whispered honestly, feeling and probably looking like an emotional wreck.

Somehow, Prime's laughter only grew louder after her confession, but no one in the audience joined her this time. Adora glanced at the window behind her, watching as the sun began to set with fear in her eyes, before turning to Catra.

“There's something I need to show you… but you need to promise you won't get scared…” She whispered, opening and closing her fist as she spoke.

“What- What do you mean?” Catra asked, but Adora placed a finger on her mouth to shut her up, and when she pulled, the brunette realised that her nails were suddenly very, *very* long.

“*Shit*…” Adora mumbled, falling into Catra's arms with a whine of pain. Catra watched in horror as a hole was ripped in the base of her back, a long tail slipping out and swaying from side to side. Adora's soft skin suddenly grew much more fluffy as the princess bit into Catra's clothes so that she wouldn't scream, but that wasn't even the worst part of the transformation. The princess's human ears ceased to exist as her hair banded together into two fluffy ears, Adora screaming so loud that even Catra's clothes couldn't muffle it.

When it stopped and she finally looked up at Catra, her princess had transformed into a magicat just like her. Suddenly, it clicked in Catra's mind, Adora's knowledge of magicat stories, the insistence to hide in caves and huts, the avoidance of any topic related to her curse. Adora turned into a magicat at night, and it seemed to embarrass her for some reason.

“*Ugh*! It's hideous!” Prime exclaimed, giving Adora a look of disgust. Catra growled and hugged the princess tighter while Adora buried her face in Catra's neck, still recovering from the pain of her transformation. “No wonder you fell in love! You both are the same kind of evil! Guards! Arrest them both!”

Catra snarled at all the guards that tried to approach them, keeping one hand around her princess while the Desert Roses all jumped at the opportunity to defend the two of them.

It was all in vain.

It didn't take long for a soldier to wrench Adora away from her, her princess screaming as she tried to reach out to Catra.

“No! Let go of her!” Catra yelled, only for a soldier to trap her hands behind her back. “Adora! I'll come back for you, I promise!” Adora only cried louder at that, trying to nudge her elbow into the guard so that she could escape.

“Don't touch her!” Catra slammed her head backwards to knock out the guard holding her, only for two more to grab her arms and kick her back, sending her to her knees.

“The marriage is binding, I am now the King of Duloc!” Prime declared, slamming his crown onto his head, before drawing his sword and walking towards Adora.

“Get away from her Prime!” The brunette warned, trying to pull her hand away from the guards, but it was useless.

By now, the other hybrids were flooding into the palace, weapons and claws drawn as they began to take down the guards one by one, but there were too many guards for the hybrids to fight, and slowly they were being captured as well.

Prime grinned at Catra, before placing his sword under Adora's chin. “I think I shall take your lover’s life in front of you, before locking you up in your tower for the rest of your life, while I use you as I see fit. You are my wife after all…”

“I'll haunt your nightmares if you even look at her wrong!” Catra was wiggling too much now, trying to reach her princess only for a guard to place a sword at her neck, a silent threat forcing her to remain still.

Prime began to cackle, looking at the chaos in his palace with manic glee. “I am now the king of Duloc, and I shall rule this kingdom however I see fit! I shall bring my light to the darkest corners of Etheria, I will ensure that no corner of the planet is spared from my rule! Prime shall rule eternal!”

The window crashed open as Opie and Melog interrupted the party fashionably late. Prime stepped away, his face a mask of confusion as Opie snarled at him, before grabbing him with her mouth and swallowing him whole, spitting out his crown a few seconds later.

“**God**, that was annoying.” Melog huffed, shaking out their fur before leaning down to smile at Opie. “Good job babe!”

Catra sighed in relief, ears drooping a little now that she could finally feel some peace from Prime’s maniacal rambling. The soldiers began to let them go, and as soon as she was released, Catra ran over to Adora and pulled her princess to her feet.

Adora pulled Catra into a tight hug, burying her face in the brunette's shoulder to breathe in her scent. "Oh my god, we're okay…" She whispered. "I thought I was going to lose you." Adora turned around, tears streaming down her face as she gave Opie a wobbly smile. "Thank you…"

Opie released a low sound in response, leaning down to push Adora closer to Catra, to which the princess giggled. "Okay, okay I'll talk to her." Adora relented, facing Catra with a stupidly fond look.

"You came back for me…" The blonde mumbled.

"I made a mistake in letting you go in the first place." Catra's face fell, and she pressed her forehead against Adora's. "Adora I'm so sorry, you've been nothing but loving since we met, but I keep seeing all the wrong things. I promise, I'm going to do better, I'm going to learn to trust and *love* better. You're the best thing that happened to me."

Adora cupped her cheeks, moving Catra's face so that they could face each other properly. "Well, I'll always be here, I'm not leaving. I love you, Catra."

"I love you too."

When their lips met, Catra could feel the wind swirling around them with untamed power. Something was changing, and when Catra pulled away, she found Adora glowing so bright she needed to cover her eyes.

When it dimmed and Catra could open her eyes, Adora was giving herself a once over, her eyes widening as tears streamed down her sweet face.

"I- I don't get it! I'm not supposed to *stay* like this! I'm supposed to change back into a human, I-" Adora pulled away, looking over her hands and her palm, flexing her claws and wailing when she realised she wouldn't be able to change back. Catra immediately reached for the blonde, grabbing her hands tightly so that Adora wouldn't do anything drastic like hurting herself.

"Adora it's okay-" Catra assured, but her princess wasn't listening to anything.

"No, no you don't get it, it's not okay! I'm supposed to be beautiful, I'm supposed to *perfect*! I'm not beautiful or perfect like this! You don't want me like **this**!" Adora responded, her panic making her screams echo throughout the hall. The Desert Roses were neutralizing the guards in the background, even their cries of pain were softer than Adora's voice.

Catra didn't raise her voice against Adora. "Why wouldn't I want you?" She asked her gently, rubbing her thumb against Adora's hand.

"Because I'm a *monster*, a freak…" The blonde responded, tears staining her face and taking her mascara with it. Catra patiently cupped Adora's face, rubbing her tears and mascara away with a soft smile.

"Like me?" She teased, flicking her ears and her tail to seal her point.

“You’re different, you’re meant to be like that. I’m abnormal, a human and a magicat…” Catra just chuckled and pressed her forehead against Adora’s.

“I don’t care, princess. I love you, and I *mean* that. I don’t pick and choose the sides of you, because I want **all** of you. Every part is beautiful, you don’t need to cry and worry that I’ll not like them, because I love you unconditionally.” Catra pulled away for a moment so that she could face Adora properly. The blonde had stopped crying, but she was still unsure of Catra’s words.

That’s okay, it’s normal, she needs time to believe it. Catra will be there every step of the way.

“I love you, Adora. You’ll always be beautiful to me, inside and outside.” She assured, knowing it won’t be the first time she says those words. She didn’t mind, she’ll say it how many ever times Adora needed it.

“I love you too.” Adora responded, giving the brunette a shy smile, before leaning forward for a soft kiss. Catra could hear the rest of the hybrids giggling and cheering for them, but at that moment she simply ignored them, and relished the feeling of Adora against her, knowing that her future would be sunny and bright with the blonde in it.

✦ . ⁺ . ✦ . ⁺ . ✦

Chapter End Notes

wow so this was a wild ride.

Thank you to everyone who's shown this fic support! honestly I rlly appreciate it.

Thank you to beta readers Lesbian Simp (for chapters 1-5, you also wrote a lot for this fic as well like the mirror's speeches and the fairy tale from chapter 5. ily so much <3) and Thia Kerrigan (for chapter 6).

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!